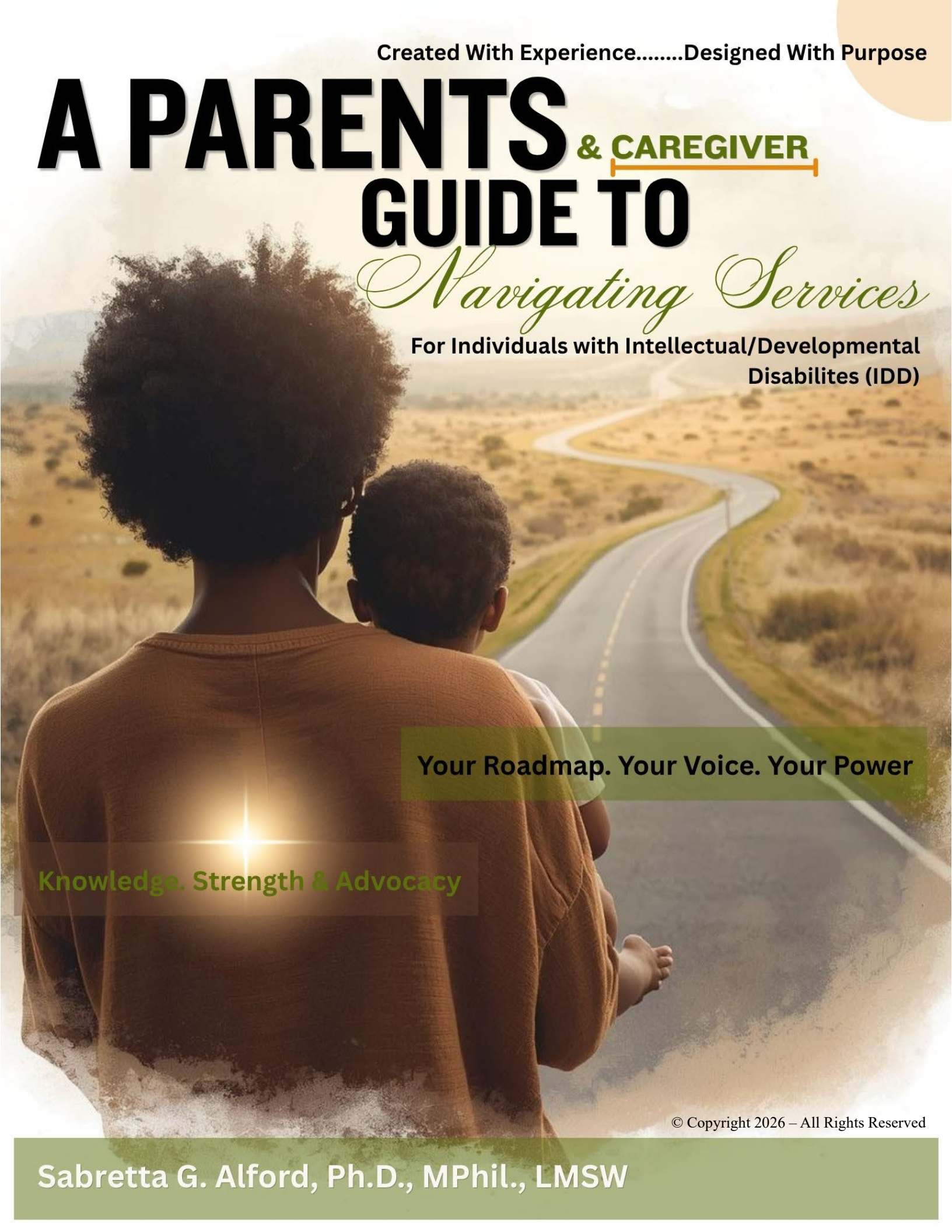
Created With Experience.....Designed With Purpose

A PARENTS & CAREGIVER GUIDE TO *Navigating Services*

For Individuals with Intellectual/Developmental Disabilites (IDD)



Your Roadmap. Your Voice. Your Power

Knowledge. Strength & Advocacy

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Sabretta G. Alford, Ph.D., MPhil., LMSW

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Parent Handbook

Navigating OPWDD Services for Families of Individuals with Intellectual and Developmental Disabilities (I/DD)

A Practical Guide to Accessing Supports Through OPWDD

Sabretta Alford, PhD, MPhil, LMSW

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About the Author and Development of This Handbook

Navigating services for a child with intellectual and developmental disabilities (I/DD) is not only a process; it is a journey! It requires persistence, knowledge, advocacy, and resilience. For many families, this journey begins with uncertainty and quickly becomes an ongoing effort to understand and engage with complex systems of care. This handbook was developed as a practical guide and an empowerment tool to support parents in accessing services, understanding systems, and advocating effectively for their children.

My name is **Dr. Sabretta Alford,** and this work is deeply rooted in both my professional expertise and my lived experience. I am a scholar in social welfare and research, a social work educator, and a practitioner with a strong focus on intellectual and developmental disabilities. My academic and professional work centers on improving service delivery systems, advancing disability-informed social work education, and developing frameworks that promote ethical, person-centered, and family-centered care.

I teach graduate-level courses in Intellectual Disabilities in Social Work Practice, preparing and training social workers to support individuals with autism and other developmental disabilities, as well as their caregivers. In addition, I mentor social workers in developing the skills, knowledge, and confidence needed to work with individuals and families navigating complex service systems.

I am also the developer of the Person-Centered Ethics of Care (PC-EoC) Model, a framework that emphasizes dignity, relational autonomy, interdependence, and structural responsiveness in working with individuals with disabilities and their families. This model informs my approach to both research and practice, and it is reflected throughout this handbook in the emphasis on family voice, individualized care, and system accountability.

However, beyond my professional roles, I am also a parent of a young adult with autism, intellectual disability, and epilepsy, which has shaped my understanding of this system in profound ways. I have personally navigated the challenges of securing services, coordinating care, managing crises, and advocating within fragmented, difficult-to-access systems. I understand firsthand the emotional, logistical, and financial realities that families face. I also understand the strength, creativity, and determination that parents bring to this journey.

My experience with my son shaped this handbook.

Too often, families are expected to navigate services without clear guidance, leading to delays, missed opportunities, and unnecessary stress.

Systems such as the Office for People with Developmental Disabilities (OPWDD) offer a wide range of valuable supports; however, the key to accessing these services requires knowledge, organization, and consistent follow-through. Yes, there is a significant gap, to equitable access to care.

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The purpose of this handbook is to bridge that gap and make it easier for families to navigate by providing clear steps (as much as I can). With this in mind, this guide:

- Provide a step-by-step guide to accessing services
- Offer clear explanations of systems and processes
- Equip parents with practical tools and strategies
- Empower families to become effective advocates
- Promote a person-centered and family-centered approach to care

At its core, this handbook is grounded in the belief that ***families are not passive recipients of services; we are central partners in care***. We know our children best, and their voices must be respected, valued, and integrated into all aspects of service planning and delivery.

Accessing services for individuals with I/DD should not be a struggle; it should be a coordinated, supportive process that honors the dignity and needs of both the individual and their family. Until systems fully reflect this ideal, it is essential that families are equipped with the knowledge and tools to navigate them effectively.

This handbook is for you, **THE PARENT, THE CAREGIVER, THE ADVOCATE**, **THE LIGHT**, who is working every day to ensure the best possible outcomes for your child.

You are not alone in this process, and with the right information and support, you can navigate this system with confidence and clarity.

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Where to Begin

If you are reading this, you are likely trying to figure out how to get the right support and services for your child, and that is not an easy process. Many parents are given information about services, but not clear guidance on what to actually do next, where to start, or how to move things forward. Well…….

This handbook was created just for you.

I wanted to put together something that goes beyond just explaining services. This guide focuses on real steps, what you need to do, when to do it, how to say it, and how to stay on track. It also includes direct contacts and resources, so you are not left searching for answers on your own.

I understand how frustrating and overwhelming this process can feel. You may find yourself making calls, following up, waiting, and trying to make sense of things that are not always clearly explained. This guide is here to help make that process a little more manageable and a lot clearer.

You can come back to this handbook whenever you need it, whether you are just getting started or already in the system. Think of it as a tool to help you stay organized, ask the right questions, and move forward with confidence as you advocate for your child.

With The Right Knowledge, YOU CAN and WILL navigate this complex system.

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Understanding the Service Delivery System

Key Systems You Will Use

This section helps you understand the main systems that provide services and support for your child. At first, these systems may feel confusing, but each one plays a specific role in helping your child access care, funding, and services.

Here, you will learn who does what, who to contact, and how everything connects—so you can move through the process with more clarity and confidence.

> Think of this as your starting point for understanding how the system works.

OPWDD (Office for People with Developmental Disabilities)

- Website: https://opwdd.ny.gov
- Main Line: 1-866-946-9733

OPWDD is the main agency in New York State that helps individuals with intellectual and developmental disabilities access services. They determine eligibility, guide families through the process, and connect you to supports such as respite, community habilitation, and residential services.

Medicaid (NY State Department of Health)

- Website: https://www.health.ny.gov/health_care/medicaid/
- Helpline: 1-800-541-2831

Medicaid is the primary insurance that pays for most OPWDD services. Your child must have Medicaid in order to receive many of these supports, including home and community-based services.

NY Medicaid Managed Care (Enrollment Help)

- Phone: 1-800-505-5678

This line helps you enroll in a Medicaid health plan or make changes to your current plan. They can guide you through selecting coverage that works best for your child's medical and service needs.

How These Systems Work Together

Think of these systems as a team, but each has a different role:

- Medicaid pays for the services
- OPWDD decides what services your child is eligible for
- Agencies/Providers actually deliver the services

In simple terms: **Medicaid = funding, OPWDD = approval → Agencies = service delivery**

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What This Means for You as a Parent

Step	What Happens	What You Need to Know
1	Medicaid is approved	This unlocks access to most services
2	OPWDD determines eligibility	They review evaluations and documents
3	Services are approved	You can begin choosing providers
4	Agencies provide services	Your child begins receiving support

Important: A Common Point of Confusion

- Many parents believe OPWDD provides the services directly.
- **This is not the case.** OPWDD **approves** services. **Agencies** provide the actual staff and support
- This is why you may need to contact multiple agencies after approval.

Getting Started: First Steps

Step 1: Learn About Services
Explore services here:
https://opwdd.ny.gov/types-services

This website provides an overview of the different types of services available through OPWDD. Take time to review what support exists so you can better understand what may be helpful for your child and family.

Step 2: Create a Needs List (See Sample)
Write down:
• Daily living needs
• Behavioral supports
• Family support needs

Before entering the system, it is important to think about what your child and family truly need. Writing this down will help you clearly communicate with service providers and ensure that the support you receive is meaningful and appropriate.

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SAMPLE NEEDS LIST

Area of Need	What My Child Needs Support With	Current Challenges	Type of Support Needed	Priority (High/Medium/Low)
Daily Living Skills	(e.g., dressing, bathing, eating)	(e.g., needs full assistance with dressing)	(e.g., 1:1 support, community habilitation)	
Communication	(e.g., non-verbal, limited speech)	(e.g., difficulty expressing needs)	(e.g., speech therapy, AAC device)	
Behavior	(e.g., aggression, self-injury, elopement)	(e.g., behaviors when frustrated or overstimulated)	(e.g., behavioral support, IB services)	
Social Skills	(e.g., interacting with others)	(e.g., limited peer engagement)	(e.g., social groups, recreation programs)	
Education/Day Program	(e.g., school support, structured day)	(e.g., needs structured routine)	(e.g., day habilitation, school supports)	
Safety	(e.g., wandering, lack of awareness)	(e.g., runs off in public spaces)	(e.g., supervision, safety planning)	
Health/Medical	(e.g., epilepsy, medications)	(e.g., needs monitoring for seizures)	(e.g., nursing support, medical coordination)	
Family Support Needs	(e.g., caregiver stress, time for self-care)	(e.g., no breaks, burnout)	(e.g., respite services)	
Community Access	(e.g., going out safely, activities)	(e.g., difficulty in public settings)	(e.g., 1:1 staff for outings)	
Future Planning	(e.g., independence, housing)	(e.g., unsure of long-term options)	(e.g., residential planning, transition services)	

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Getting Your Document Ready Before The Process Begins

Preparing In Advance

This section helps you get organized by outlining the important documents you should begin gathering before or during the process. Having these documents ready can speed things up and reduce delays.

You don't need everything at once, but starting early will make a big difference.

> Think of this, as getting your paperwork ready so you can move through the process more smoothly.

Why This Matters

Before or during the Front Door process, it's important to begin gathering key documents that will be used to determine your child's eligibility for services.

Having these ready **early** can:

- Speed up the process
- Prevent delays
- Reduce stress later on

Documents to Gather

Document	What It Is	What to Do
Psychological Evaluation	Assesses cognitive functioning, diagnosis, and developmental needs	Request from a licensed psychologist or agency; ensure standardized testing is included
Psychosocial Evaluation	Provides background on your child's history, behavior, and family context	Ask a social worker, agency, or clinic to complete this
Medical Diagnosis	Confirms diagnosis (e.g., autism, I/DD) from a qualified medical provider	Request documentation from your child's doctor or specialist
School Records (IEP)	Shows educational needs, supports, and services	Request most recent IEP and evaluations from your child's school

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Now, Here Is What to Do Step-by-Step

Make a list of what you already have

- Check your home records, emails, or school documents

Request missing documents immediately

Contact:

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- Schools (for IEP and evaluations)
- Doctors (for medical records)
- Agencies or clinics (for evaluations)

Ask for UPDATED evaluations if needed

- Older reports may need to be redone

Keep copies of everything

- Create a folder or binder (physical or digital)

Follow up regularly

- Do not assume documents are being processed

⚠️ Important Notes About Evaluations

- ☐ Evaluations should include standardized test scores
- ☐ Reports should clearly describe your child's needs
- ☐ Strong documentation = smoother eligibility process

If something feels unclear or incomplete, ask for clarification

Parent Tip

Start gathering documents as early as possible, even before your first meeting.

- ☐ The earlier you prepare, the less stressful the process will be.

The more prepared you are,
The smoother the process will go.

You don't need everything all at once—just start……..
One document at a time……
One step at a time…….
You're building something important for your child.

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Document Request Scripts

What to Say to Schools, Doctors & Agencies

This section provides simple scripts for requesting documents for your child. You can read them directly, copy them into an email, or adjust them as needed.

You do not need perfect words, just be clear and direct.

---

1. **Requesting School Records (IEP, Evaluations)**

Call or Email Script: *"Hello, my name is [Your Name], and I am requesting a copy of my child's most recent IEP and any evaluations on file. I need these documents for service coordination and eligibility purposes. Can you please let me know how I can obtain them and how long it will take?*"

If needed, add: *"Please include any psychological or educational assessments."*

2. **Requesting a Psychological Evaluation**

Script: *"Hello, I am seeking a psychological evaluation for my child as part of the process for accessing services. I would like to ensure the evaluation includes standardized testing and a detailed report. Can you guide me through how to schedule this?"*

3. **Requesting a Psychosocial Evaluation**

Script: *"Hi, I am in the process of applying for services and need a psychosocial evaluation for my child. Can you let me know if your agency provides this and how I can get started?"*

4. **Requesting Medical Records / Diagnosis**

Script (Doctor's Office): *"Hello, I am requesting documentation of my child's diagnosis and any relevant medical records. I need this for service eligibility purposes. Can you please let me know the process and timeline for receiving these documents?"*

Add if needed: *"I would like the documentation to clearly state the diagnosis."*

5. **Following Up on a Request**

Script: *"Hello, I'm following up on my request for my child's records. I wanted to check on the status and see when I can expect to receive them."*

If needed: *Please let me know if anything is needed from me to move this forward."*

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If You Experience Delays

Script: *"I understand these requests take time, but I wanted to follow up as this documentation is needed to move forward with services for my child. Is there anything that can be done to expedite the process?"*

Email Template (Copy & Paste)

Subject: Request for Records – [Child's Name]

Hello,
My name is [Your Name], and I am requesting copies of my child's records, including [IEP/evaluations/medical documentation]. These are needed for service eligibility and coordination.

Please let me know the process for obtaining these documents and the expected timeline. Thank you for your assistance.

Best,

[Your Name]

[Your Contact Information]

Parent Tips

- Always ask for a **timeline**
- Follow up if you don't hear back within **5–7 days**
- Keep copies of everything you receive
- Write down who you spoke to

Clear requests + follow-up = faster results

- You are allowed to ask for these documents.
- They are part of your child's record, and part of your right as a parent.

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The Office for People with Developmental Disabilities (OPWDD) "Front Door" Process

The "Front Door" is the official starting point for accessing services through OPWDD. Every family must go through this process to determine if their child is eligible for support.

This section will guide you step-by-step through getting started, what to expect, and what you need to do along the way. While it may feel like a lot at first, this process opens the door to important services and resources for your child.

Think of this as your entry point into the system—it's where everything begins.

Start Here (MANDATORY)

- https://opwdd.ny.gov/get-started
- https://opwdd.ny.gov/get-started/front-door

→ This is the official starting point for all OPWDD services. Every family must go through the "Front Door" process to determine eligibility and begin receiving supports. These websites will guide you on how to register and what to expect.

What to Do

1. **Register online**
   → Begin by creating an account or submitting your information through the OPWDD website. This officially starts the process and places your child into the system for review.

2. **Attend a Front Door Information Session**
   → You will be required to attend an orientation (virtual or in-person) where OPWDD explains available services, the eligibility process, and next steps. This is an important step to understanding how everything works.

3. **Begin eligibility process**
   → After the session, you will move forward with submitting documents (evaluations, diagnosis, etc.) so OPWDD can determine if your child qualifies for services.

Metro New York DDRO (Manhattan/Queens/Bronx)

- 646-766-3220

This office serves families in Manhattan, Queens, and the Bronx. You can call here for help with starting the process, checking your application status, or asking questions about eligibility and services.

Brooklyn DDRO

- 718-642-6000

This office supports families living in Brooklyn. They can guide you through the intake process, answer questions, and assist with eligibility and service coordination.

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Staten Island DDRO

- 718-983-5200

This office serves Staten Island families. You can contact them for assistance with starting services, follow-ups, and general support throughout the process.

Long Island DDRO

- 631-326-4400

This office supports families in Nassau and Suffolk counties. They provide guidance on eligibility, services, and connecting to local providers.

These offices determine eligibility and guide intake.

What to Expect (Timeline & Reality)

→ The Front Door process does **not happen overnight**.

- The process can take **several weeks to several months**, depending on:
- How quickly documents are submitted
- Appointment availability

Review timelines

- **Important:** Delays are common—this is normal.

What You Should Prepare in Advance

- Before or during the Front Door process, begin gathering:
- Psychological evaluation
- Psychosocial evaluation
- Medical diagnosis
- School records (IEP, if available)

Having these ready will help ***speed up eligibility review***.

Parent Tip: Do Not Wait! Follow Up

After each step:

- Call to confirm your registration was received
- Confirm your attendance is recorded after the session
- Ask: "What are my next steps?"

Following up keeps your case active.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

- Waiting for someone to call you back
- Not attending the Front Door session (this will delay everything)
- Submitting incomplete documents
- Not keeping copies of what you submit

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Your involvement matters at every step.

What Happens After Eligibility Is Approved

Once your child is approved:

- You will be assigned a Care Manager
- You will begin creating a service plan (ISP)
- You will choose service providers
- Services will be authorized and started

Approval is just the beginning. The next phase is **service setup**.

Questions You Should Ask During This Process

- "Is my application complete?"
- "Are any documents missing?"
- "What is the current timeline?"
- "What happens after eligibility is approved?"

Asking these questions keeps you informed and prepared.

The Front Door process is your **ENTRY POINT INTO SERVICES**.

- Stay Focused
- Stay organized
- Stay involved
- Stay consistent

This is how you move forward.

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Eligibility & Required Documentation

This section explains what you need to prove that your child qualifies for services and how to prepare the required paperwork. This includes evaluations, medical records, and other important documents that help show your child's needs.

Getting these documents together is a very important step, as they are used to determine eligibility and move your application forward.

Think of this as building your child's "file"—the stronger and more complete it is, the smoother the process will be.

You Will Need

- **Psychological evaluation**
  → This assessment helps show your child's cognitive functioning and confirms the presence of an intellectual or developmental disability.

- **Psychosocial evaluation**
  → This provides information about your child's behavior, emotional functioning, and daily living skills, helping to show how the disability impacts everyday life.

- **Medical diagnosis**
  → A diagnosis from a doctor (such as autism, intellectual disability, cerebral palsy, etc.) is required to confirm eligibility for services.

Where to Find Evaluations

You can locate providers through OPWDD:

- https://opwdd.ny.gov/providers
  → This website allows you to search for agencies and professionals who can complete the required evaluations.

- Or contact your local DDSO for referrals.
  → Your local office can guide you to trusted providers in your area and help you understand how to schedule evaluations.

➡ EVALUATIONS: What Parents Need to Know

I strongly recommend that you find an agency that conducts standardized evaluations, meaning they use formal testing tools that provide clear scores and detailed results. These types of evaluations are important because they offer a more accurate and complete understanding of your child's needs and diagnosis.

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You will need these evaluations when applying for Medicaid and OPWDD services (including Medicaid Waiver services and Care Coordination)**.** OPWDD relies on this documentation to determine eligibility and ensure that your child receives the appropriate level of support.

Evaluations typically take about one hour or longer**,** depending on your child's needs and the type of assessment being completed. After the evaluation, the agency should provide you with a written report. In most cases, you can expect to receive the results within a few weeks**.**

Once completed, these evaluation reports will be submitted as part of your child's application to OPWDD (formerly known as the Office of Mental Retardation and Developmental Disabilities). These documents are reviewed to determine eligibility for services and supports.

Parent Tip

- Always keep copies of all evaluation reports in a safe place (both digital and printed).
- You will likely need to submit them multiple times throughout the process.

Special Note: Evaluations Are Critical

I strongly recommend that you choose an agency that provides standardized evaluations with formal test scores**.** These evaluations are extremely important because they offer a clearer, more accurate understanding of your child's diagnosis and overall needs.

You will need these evaluation reports when applying for Medicaid and OPWDD services (including Medicaid Waiver and Care Coordination)**.** Without proper documentation, your application may be delayed or denied.

Evaluations typically take about an hour or longer**,** depending on your child. After the assessment, the agency should provide you with a written report. In most cases, you can expect to receive the results within a few weeks**.**

These reports will be submitted to OPWDD (formerly known as the Office of Mental Retardation and Developmental Disabilities) as part of the eligibility review process.

- **Important:** Always request and keep copies of all evaluation reports. You will likely need to submit them multiple times throughout your child's service journey.

Common Mistakes Parents Make with Evaluations (and How to Avoid Them)

1. **Choosing agencies that do not provide standardized testing**
   → Some evaluations are too general and do not include formal test scores.
   What to do instead: Ask if the evaluation includes standardized assessments with scores (this is critical for OPWDD).

2. **Waiting too long to schedule evaluations**
   → Delays in evaluations will delay the entire service process.

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What to do instead: Schedule evaluations as early as possible—even while starting other steps.

3. **Not receiving or keeping copies of reports**
   → Many parents assume the agency will send everything where it needs to go.
   What to do instead: Always request copies (digital and printed) and keep them organized.

4. **Using outdated evaluations**
   → OPWDD may not accept evaluations that are too old.
   What to do instead: Confirm timelines with OPWDD or your Care Manager to ensure reports are current.

5. **Not reviewing the evaluation for accuracy**
   → Reports may contain errors or incomplete information.
   What to do instead: Read the report carefully and ask for corrections if needed.

6. **Relying on only one provider**
   → Some agencies have long waitlists or limited services.
   What to do instead: Contact multiple agencies to compare availability and quality.

Evaluation Checklist Page (Parent Tool)

Use this checklist before, during, and after your child's evaluation to make sure everything is complete and useful.

Before the Evaluation

☐ I contacted more than one agency to compare options
☐ I confirmed the evaluation includes standardized testing with scores
☐ I asked about wait times and report turnaround
☐ I verified the provider is a licensed professional (psychologist, etc.)
☐ I gathered any existing records (school reports, IEP, medical records)

During the Evaluation

☐ The evaluator asked about my child's:
- Communication
- Behavior
- Daily living skills
- Social skills

☐ My child completed structured testing (not just observation)
☐ I had the opportunity to share concerns and goals

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After the Evaluation

☐ I received a written report
☐ The report includes standardized test scores
☐ A clear diagnosis is stated
☐ The report explains how the disability impacts daily functioning
☐ There are specific service recommendations
☐ The report is recent and up to date

Important
☐ I saved copies of the report:
- Digital copy (email or PDF)
- Printed copy (folder or binder)

Reminder: You will need to submit this report multiple times, keep it safe and organized.

➡ **What to Say When Calling an Evaluation Agency (Parent Script)**

Use this script when calling agencies. You can read it directly or adjust it to your comfort level.

Opening
- "Hello, I'm calling because I need a psychological and psychosocial evaluation for my child for OPWDD services."

Key Questions to Ask

1. **About the Evaluation**
   "Do you provide standardized evaluations with formal test scores?"
   "I want to make sure the evaluation will be accepted by OPWDD."

2. **About Experience**
   "Do you have experience working with children with autism or developmental disabilities?"

3. **About Timing**
   "What is your current wait time for an appointment?"
   "How long does it take to receive the written report after the evaluation?"

4. **About Documentation**
   "Will the report include a clear diagnosis and detailed recommendations?"

5. **About Insurance / Payment**
   "Do you accept Medicaid?"
   "If not, what is the cost of the evaluation?"

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6. **Closing**
   "Thank you. I am contacting a few agencies, so I will follow up soon."

Parent Tip

- If something does not feel right, or the agency cannot clearly answer your questions…**Keep looking.**
- You deserve a provider who understands your child and the OPWDD process.

Call Tracking Log (Parent Tool)

Use this log to keep track of all calls, emails, and follow-ups. This will help you stay organized and avoid delays.

Instructions

- Write down every call, email, or message
- Always note the date, name, and outcome
- Keep track of next steps and follow-ups

Sample
Call / Contact Log Table

Date	Agency/ Office	Person Spoken To	Phone/Email	Reason for Contact	Outcome/ Notes	Follow-Up Needed	Follow-Up Date

Important Reminders

- Always ask for the **person's name and title**
- Write down exactly what was said (as much as possible)
- If someone says they will call you back, **write it down and follow up**
- If you do not hear back within a few days, **call again. Keep calling until you get an answer**

Parent Tip

- Do not rely on memory.
- Keeping a detailed log protects you, keeps things moving, and helps you stay in control of the process.

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Service Planning & Care Coordination

Once your child is approved for services, this is the step where everything starts to come together. You will be assigned a Care Manager who will help you plan, organize, and connect to the services your child needs.

This section explains how your child's service plan is created, what your Care Manager should be doing, and how you can stay involved throughout the process.

Think of this as building your child's support plan—with you at the center of every decision.

After your child is approved for OPWDD services, you will be assigned a Care Manager through a Care Management Organization (CMO).

Your **Care Manager** becomes one of the most important people in this process—they are responsible for helping you plan, organize, and access services for your child.

Care Managers help you:

- Develop your child's Individualized Service Plan (ISP)
- Identify your child's needs, goals, and supports
- Connect you to service providers and agencies
- Coordinate services across multiple systems (medical, educational, social)
- Monitor services to ensure they are working effectively

Your **Care Manager** is expected to:

- **Keep you informed and updated regularly**
- Explain services in a way you understand
- Respond to your calls and emails in a timely manner
- Help move services forward (not delay them)
- Advocate for appropriate services based on your child's needs

You should never feel confused, ignored, or left out of the process.

If You Are Not Hearing Back

- If your Care Manager is not responsive:
- Follow up (phone/email)
- Document all communication
- Ask to speak with a **supervisor**

Contact the Care Management Organization (CMO) directly

- **You have the right to support and communication.**

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Care Management Organizations (CMOs)
Advance Care Alliance (ACA/NYC)
833-320-6589
https://acany.org

- Provides care coordination services and supports families in navigating OPWDD services throughout New York City.

Care Design NY
631-761-8500
https://caredesignny.org

- One of the largest CMOs in New York, offering care management services and connecting families to a wide range of supports.

Important Note

- **You may have a choice between Care Management Organizations.**
- If one does not meet your needs, you can request a **change.**

Parent Tip: Stay Involved in Service Planning

- Even though you have a Care Manager:
  - **You are still the most important voice in the process.**

Ask questions

- Share your concerns
- Speak up about what your child needs

IMPORTANT: Your Care Manager is your **partner in navigating services**, not someone who replaces your voice or role.

- The best outcomes happen when:
  - You stay involved
  - You stay informed
  - You work together

What a Good Care Manager Looks Like vs. Red Flags

Area	✅ What a Good Care Manager Looks Like	🚩 Red Flags (What to Watch For)
Communication	Responds to calls/emails within a reasonable time	Does not return calls or takes weeks to respond
Updates	Keeps you informed about your child's case and next steps	You are left unsure about what is happening
Clarity	Explains services clearly and answers questions	Uses confusing language or avoids answering questions
Availability	Makes time for meetings and check-ins	Hard to reach or frequently unavailable
Support	Helps move services forward and connects you to providers	Leaves you to figure things out on your own

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Advocacy	Supports your child's needs and speaks up when needed	Minimizes your concerns or dismisses your input
Organization	Keeps track of documents and follows up on submissions	Loses paperwork or asks for the same documents repeatedly
Planning	Actively helps develop a meaningful service plan (ISP)	Rushed or incomplete service planning
Respect	Treats you as a partner and listens to you	Makes you feel unheard, dismissed, or disrespected
Follow-Through	Follows up on tasks and keeps things moving	Promises action but does not follow through

➡ **Important Reminder.** If you notice multiple red flags: **Do not ignore them. Take action.**
What You Can Do

Step	Action
1	Follow up directly with your Care Manager
2	Document all communication
3	Request a meeting to address concerns
4	Contact the Care Management Organization (CMO)
5	Ask to speak with a supervisor
6	Request a new Care Manager (if needed)

Parent Empowerment Tip (Do Not Tolerate Poor Service Delivery!)

- You are not expected to accept poor communication or lack of support.
- You have the right to:
  - Be informed
  - Be respected
  - Be supported

Remember this:

- A good Care Manager helps you move forward**.**
- A poor one creates delays and confusion**.**

➡ If something feels off, trust yourself and speak up.

How to Request a New Care Manager
When It's Not Working, You Have Options (Know this!)

When Should You Consider Requesting a New Care Manager?

You may want to request a change if:

- Your Care Manager is ***unresponsive***
- You are ***not*** receiving updates or guidance
- Your concerns are *not being taken seriously*

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- Services are *not moving forward*
- You feel *unsupported or confused*

If this happens consistently, it is okay to take action.

Step-by-Step: What to Do

Step	Action
1	Follow up directly with your Care Manager first
2	Clearly express your concerns
3	Document all communication (calls, emails)
4	Contact the Care Management Organization (CMO)
5	Ask to speak with a supervisor
6	Request a new Care Manager

What to Say **(Simple Script)**

Option 1: Direct but Respectful

"I appreciate the support so far, but I feel that my child's needs are not being fully addressed. I would like to request a new Care Manager to better support our situation."

Option 2: If There Are Ongoing Issues

"I have had difficulty with communication and follow-through, and I am concerned about delays in my child's services. At this time, I would like to request a new Care Manager."

Option 3: If You Need to Escalate

"I would like to speak with a supervisor regarding concerns about care coordination and to request a reassignment."

Email Version (You Can Copy & Send)

Subject: Request for New Care Manager

Hello,

I am writing to request a reassignment of my child's Care Manager. At this time, I feel that our needs are not being fully supported, particularly in the areas of communication and service coordination. I would appreciate assistance in assigning a new Care Manager who can help ensure that services move forward appropriately.

Thank you for your time and support. I look forward to your response.

Sincerely,

[Your Name]

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Contact the Care Management Organization (CMO)
If needed, contact directly:

Advance Care Alliance (ACA/NYC)
833-320-6589
https://acany.org

Care Design NY
631-761-8500
https://caredesignny.org

Important Notes

- You do **not** need permission to request a change
- You do **not** need to feel guilty
- This is about getting the **right support for your child**

Parent Empowerment Reminder
Advocating for better support is not being difficult, it is being responsible.

- The goal is not conflict.
  The goal is **effective support for your child**.

Simple Takeaway
If something is not working:

- Speak up
- Take action
- Ask for what your child needs

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Types of Services Available

This section introduces the different services your child may be eligible to receive through OPWDD. These can include support at home, in the community, during the day, and even long-term living options.

You will learn what each service does, how it can help your child, and when it might be appropriate to consider.

> Think of this as your menu of supports—helping you choose what best fits your child's needs and daily life.

Explore Available Services

- https://opwdd.ny.gov/types-services

This page provides a full overview of services available through OPWDD. Reviewing this will help you understand what supports exist and begin thinking about what your child may need now and in the future.

Common OPWDD Services (THERE ARE MANY MORE!!!)

Service	Description (In Plain Language)	When You Might Need This Service
Community Habilitation (Com Hab)	One-on-one support that helps your child build everyday life skills at home or in the community	When your child needs help developing independence, social skills, or daily routines.
Respite Services (in-home & center-based)	Short-term care that gives parents and caregivers a break while ensuring your child is safely supported.	When you need time to rest, attend to other responsibilities, or prevent caregiver burnout.
Day Programs (Day Habilitation)	Structured daytime programs focused on skill-building, socialization, and meaningful activities.	When your child needs a structured daily routine, especially after aging out of school.
Recreational Programs (Afterschool, Saturday & holiday)	Engage in leisure, social, and community-based activities (e.g., group outings, arts, sports, and skill-building programs).	When your loved one would benefit from social interaction, community inclusion, and recreational experiences.
Residential Services	Housing options for individuals who need support living outside the family home (group homes, supervised settings).	When your child requires full-time support or long-term living arrangements outside the home.

Parent Tip

- It's okay if you don't need every service right away.
- Start with what your child needs **now** and build from there over time.

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Parent-Friendly Guides & Resources

This section provides helpful tools, websites, and organizations designed to support you as you navigate the system. These resources break things down in simple terms, offer guidance, and connect you with additional support.

Whether you need more information, training, or someone to talk to—these guides are here to help you feel more confident and less alone.

> Think of this as your support library—resources you can turn to whenever you need help or clarity.

Sometimes official websites can feel overwhelming. These organizations provide clear, easy-to-understand guides for families**:**

YAI (Highly Recommended Parent Resource Guides for Every Borough)

- https://www.yai.org/resources/directories-new-york-family-support-services

Visit their **Resources section** for downloadable guides on:

- OPWDD services
- Family support resources
- Transition to adulthood
- Self-Direction

YAI provides practical, easy-to-read materials designed specifically for families

INCLUDEnyc (NYC Families)

- https://includenyc.org or https://includenyc.org/help-center/resources/application-process-for-opwdd-services/

Especially helpful for:

- Education (IEP support)
- Transition planning
- Workshops and parent trainings

Parent Tip:

- Start Broad, Then Focus
- At first, you do not need to understand every service.

Start by asking:

- What does my child need **right now**?
- What might they need **in the future**?
- Then narrow your focus from there.

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Simple Takeaway

- You do not need to figure this all out at once.
    - Learn the services
    - Ask questions
    - Build your plan step by step

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Service Matching Guide: Based on Your Child's Needs

What Does My Child Need → What Service Matches?

This section helps you connect your child's specific needs to the right services. Instead of guessing what to choose, this guide shows you how to match supports based on your child's daily challenges, goals, and level of independence.

It's designed to make decision-making easier and more practical, so you can feel confident selecting services that truly fit your child.

Think of this as your roadmap—helping you choose the right supports at the right time

Service Matching Guide

If Your Child Needs…	What It Might Look Like	Recommended Service(s)	Typical Age Range	Notes for Parents
Help with daily living skills	Difficulty with routines, communication, independence	Community Habilitation (Com Hab)	All ages (childhood → adulthood)	Great starting service for many families
More social interaction	Limited peer interaction, needs engagement	Com Hab, Day Habilitation	Children → adulthood	Can be combined depending on age
A structured daily routine	Needs consistency during the day	Day Habilitation	Typically 18+ (after school ends)	Especially important after aging out of school
Support after aging out of school	No longer eligible for school-based services	Day Habilitation, Employment Services	21+	Start planning early (before age 21)
Interest in working	Wants a job but needs support	Employment Services	Late teens → adulthood	Includes job coaching and training
Behavioral support	Challenging behaviors, difficulty with transitions	Com Hab, (ask about behavioral supports)	All ages	Ensure evaluations reflect these needs
Family needs a break	Caregiver burnout, need time for other responsibilities	Respite Services	All ages	Can be used regularly or occasionally
Safety concerns at home	Needs supervision at all times	Com Hab, Respite, (possibly residential long-term)	All ag	

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Important Note About Age • Ages are **general guidelines**, not strict rules. • Services are based on: ○ Eligibility ○ Needs ○ Availability	**Parent Tip** ○ The most important transition period is ages 14–21. This is when planning for: • Adult services • Employment • Independence • should begin.

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Understanding Self-Direction (OPWDD Services)

Taking Control of Services

What It Is, How It Works, and What to Watch For

This section explains what Self-Direction is and how it allows you to have more control over your child's services. Instead of services being fully managed by an agency, Self-Direction gives you the ability to choose supports, staff, and how your child's services are set up.
You will learn how it works, what your role is, and what to expect before getting started.

> Think of this as having more flexibility and choice—while also taking on a more active role in managing your child's support system.

What Is Self-Direction?

Self-Direction is an OPWDD service option that allows you, as the parent or caregiver, to have **more control over your child's services, staff, and budget**.

- Instead of only using traditional agency-based services, Self-Direction allows you to:
- Choose who works with your child
- Decide how services are delivered
- Customize supports based on your child's unique needs

In simple terms, **Self-Direction gives you flexibility, control, and choice.**

➡ **Important: KNOW What You Are "Signing Up For"**

Self-Direction is powerful—but it also comes with responsibility**.**
You will be involved in:

- Managing staff (in some cases)
- Tracking services and hours
- Working within a budget
- Communicating regularly with your team

It is not "less work," it is **more control with more responsibility**.

The Role of the Self-Direction Broker

A Self-Direction Broker is someone who helps you set up and manage your Self-Direction plan**.**

What a Broker Should Do
A good broker will:

- Help you build a **budget based on your child's needs**
- Explain how Self-Direction works in simple terms
- Guide you through paperwork and setup
- Help you identify appropriate services and supports
- Ensure your plan aligns with OPWDD rules

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Important Warning: Not All Brokers Are the Same

Unfortunately, not all brokers provide the same level of support. Watch Out for:

- Brokers who **rush you through the process**
- Brokers who **do not explain your budget clearly**
- Brokers who **discourage your questions**
- Brokers who seem more focused on **billing than your child's needs**

You deserve a broker who is:

- Transparent
- Responsive
- Focused on your child

Protect Yourself from Brokerage Issues

- Ask questions until you fully understand
- Review your budget carefully
- Do not sign anything you are unsure about
- Keep copies of all documents
- Speak up if something does not feel right

You can request a different broker **i**f needed.

Understanding Your Budget

Your Self-Direction budget is based on:

- Your child's *needs and goals*
- Approved services
- OPWDD guidelines

Important: Your budget should reflect your child's *real needs—not a generic plan.*

Red Flags in Budgeting

- Budget seems too low for your child's needs
- Services you requested are missing
- You do not understand how funds are being used

Always ask: *"Can you walk me through this budget step by step?"*

The Three Main Parts of Self-Direction

Understanding these is key:

1. **Direct Support (Staffing)**
   → Hiring staff to work directly with your child (e.g., community habilitation workers)

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2. **Purchased Services**
   → Services provided by agencies (e.g., programs, therapies, community classes)

3. **Administrative / Support Services**
   → Services that help manage the program (e.g., broker, fiscal intermediary)

These create your full Self-Direction plan.

Key Players in Self-Direction

Role	What They Do
You (Parent)	Make decisions and guide the plan
Care Manager	Helps oversee and coordinate services
Broker	Helps design and manage the Self-Direction plan
Fiscal Intermediary (FI)	Handles payments, payroll, and financial paperwork

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Step-by-Step Guide: How to Receive Self-Direction (OPWDD)

From Approval → Full Control of Services

This section walks you through the entire Self-Direction process—from getting started to having services in place. It breaks everything down into clear, manageable steps so you know exactly what to do and what to expect along the way.

Instead of feeling overwhelmed, you'll be able to move through the process with a plan and a clear understanding of each stage.

Think of this as your step-by-step roadmap to getting Self-Direction up and running.

Step 1: Be Found Eligible for OPWDD

- ☐ Complete the Front Door process
- ☐ Submit all required evaluations and documents
- ☐ Receive official **eligibility approval letter**

You cannot start Self-Direction without OPWDD eligibility

Step 2: Ensure Medicaid Is Active

Confirm your child has **active Medicaid**

Medicaid is required because it **funds Self-Direction services**

Step 3: Get Assigned a Care Manager

- You will be assigned through a **Care Management Organization (CMO)**

Your Care Manager will:

- Introduce Self-Direction as an option
- Help guide you through the process

Step 4: Tell Your Care Manager You Want Self-Direction

- Say clearly: *"I am interested in Self-Direction for my child."*

➡ **This step is important**—Self-Direction does **not happen automatically**

Step 5: Attend a Self-Direction Information Session

- You may be required (or strongly encouraged) to attend a session

You will learn:

- How Self-Direction works
- Your responsibilities
- What to expect

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Step 6: Choose a Self-Direction Broker

- Your Care Manager will provide a list of brokers

Take your time choosing—this is very important.
Ask:

- "Can you explain Self-Direction clearly?"
- "How do you build budgets?"
- "How do you support families?"

You can **change brokers if needed**

Step 7: Choose a Fiscal Intermediary (FI)

The FI will handle:

- Payroll
- Payments
- Financial tracking

You cannot operate Self-Direction without an FI

Step 8: Develop Your Self-Direction Plan & Budget

- With your broker, you will:
- Identify your child's needs
- Choose services and supports
- Build a **budget that reflects those needs**

Important Note

Do NOT rush this step.
Make sure:

- The budget matches your child's real needs
- You understand how funds are allocated

Step 9: Submit Plan for OPWDD Approval

Your broker submits your plan
OPWDD will:

- Review the plan
- Approve or request changes

Step 10: Hire Staff / Set Up Services

Once approved:

- Hire staff (if applicable)
- Set schedules
- Finalize service arrangements

Step 11: Begin Self-Directed Services

- Services officially start

Your child now receives:

- Customized supports
- Flexible services
- Individualized care

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Ongoing Responsibilities (After Starting)

- Self-Direction continues to require:
- Monitoring services
- Communicating with your broker & Care Manager
- Staying within budget
- Making updates as needed

Common Delays (And How to Avoid Them)

Delay	What to Do
Waiting for the broker	Contact multiple brokers
Budget issues	Ask for full explanation
Approval delays	Follow up regularly
Staff hiring delays	Start recruiting early

Parent Tips for Success

- Stay involved in every step
- Ask questions until you understand
- Keep copies of everything
- Do not feel rushed
- Advocate for what your child truly needs

Self-Direction is not automatic—it is a process you actively move forward**.**

- The more engaged you are,
- the smoother the process will be.

Remember: You are building a system **around your child's life**.

- Take your time.
- Ask questions.
- Make informed decisions.

This is **YOUR** opportunity to create something that truly works for your child.

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Self-Direction: Websites, Contacts & Training Resources

This section provides the key websites, phone numbers, and training resources you need to understand and manage Self-Direction. These tools will help you learn how the process works, stay informed, and know who to contact when you need support.

> Think of this as your go-to reference for reliable information and guidance throughout your Self-Direction journey.

OPWDD Self-Direction Overview

- https://opwdd.ny.gov/types-services/self-direction
  → Explains what Self-Direction is, who qualifies, and how it works.

Self-Direction Webinar

- https://opwdd.ny.gov/news

Broker Support Contact

- SDBroker@opwdd.ny.gov

OPWDD Training Portal (SLMS System)
https://opwdd.ny.gov/providers/training
→ This is where official trainings are accessed. You can:

- Enroll in courses
- Complete Self-Direction training modules
- Access learning materials

Includes Self-Direction-related training topics and courses

Required Training (Important for Parents to Know)
Before fully starting Self-Direction, you may need to complete:

- **"Introduction to Self-Direction" training**
  → This is often required before moving forward in the process

Additional training topics may include:

- Person-Centered Planning
- Budget Development
- Self-Advocacy

These training courses help you understand your responsibilities and rights.

Broker Training & Role (For Your Understanding)

Even though YOU are not becoming a broker, it is important to understand their training:

- Brokers must complete **multiple formal training modules**
- This includes budgeting, planning, and compliance training

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This means:

- Your broker should be knowledgeable and well-trained
- If they are not explaining things clearly—that is a red flag.

Care Management Organizations (CMOs)
(NYC – All Five Boroughs)

Advance Care Alliance (ACA/NYC)
833-320-6589
https://acany.org
→ Provides care coordination and helps connect families to Self-Direction services.

Care Design NY
631-761-8500
https://caredesignny.org
→ One of the largest CMOs, supporting families through the entire process.

Fiscal Intermediary (FI) Example

Braverhood
718) 336-6073
https://www.braverhood.org/service.html

→ FI handles:

- Payroll
- Staff payments
- Budget tracking

Required for Self-Direction to operate

Parent-Friendly Training & Guidance (There Are Many More!)

YAI (Family Resources & Guides)

- https://www.yai.org

→ Go to "Resources" section for:

- Self-Direction guides
- Family-friendly explanations
- Training materials

One of the best simplified resources for parents

INCLUDEnyc (NYC Families)

- https://includenyc.org

→ Offers:

- Workshops
- Transition planning
- Parent training sessions

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Your Self-Direction Team (Circle of Support)

You will work with a team that includes:

- **Care Manager** → Coordinates services
- **Broker** → Builds and manages your budget
- **Fiscal Intermediary (FI)** → Handles payments
- **You (Parent)** → Decision-maker

This team is called your **"Circle of Support"**

Important Parent Notes About Training

Training is not just a requirement—it is **protection for you**
It helps you:

- Understand your budget
- Avoid mistakes
- Recognize when something is wrong

Parent Tip: Do Not Skip Training
Even if it feels like "a lot":

- Training = Confidence
- Confidence = Better decisions

Self-Direction is not just a service—it is a system you are managing**.**

- These websites and trainings help you:
- Understand the system
- Protect your child
- Make informed decisions

The more informed you are, the more control you have.

IN Self-Direction—**KNOWLEDGE IS EVERYTHING.**

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Self-Direction Budget Example

What a Budget Might Look Like

This is a **sample** to help you understand structure—not exact amounts

This section shows a simple example of what a Self-Direction budget may look like and how funds are used to support your child. It helps you understand how money is divided between staffing, services, and administrative costs.

The goal is to make the budget easier to understand so you can feel confident reviewing and approving your own.

Think of this as a guide to understanding where the money goes and how it supports your child's care.

Example: Monthly Self-Direction Budget

Category	Service	Example Monthly Amount	What This Means
Direct Support (Staffing)	Community Habilitation Staff	$3,200	Staff works with your child weekly to build skills
Direct Support (Staffing)	Respite	$800	Gives family breaks while child is supported
Purchased Services	Day Program / Activities	$1,200	Structured daytime or community-based programs
Administrative	Broker Fee	$300	Pays broker to manage your Self-Direction plan
Administrative	Fiscal Intermediary (FI)	$500	Covers payroll, taxes, and financial management
Other Supports	Community Classes / Activities	$200	Activities like gym, art, or social programs
			Estimated Monthly Total: $6,200

Breaking It Down

Category	% of Budget	What It Covers
Staffing (Direct Support)	~60–70%	People working directly with your child
Purchased Services	~15–25%	Programs and structured services
Administrative Costs	~10–15%	Broker + FI support

What This Means for You

- Most of your budget should go toward:
  - **Direct support for your child**

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Services that improve:

- Independence
- Safety
- Quality of life

Red Flags in a Budget

Warning Sign	What It Could Mean
Too much going to admin costs	Not enough support for your child
Budget seems too low	Needs may not be fully captured
You don't understand the numbers	Broker is not explaining clearly
Services missing	Plan does not reflect your child

Questions You Should Always Ask Your Broker

- *"Can you walk me through this budget step by step?"*
- *"How does this reflect my child's actual needs?"*
- *"Can we adjust this if something is missing?"*

If you don't understand it, it needs to be explained again.

Important: Budgets Can Be Updated

Your child's needs may change.

You can:

- Request changes
- Add services
- Adjust hours

Self-Direction is meant to be **flexible**

Parent Tip: Be Realistic, Not Perfect

You do not need the "perfect" budget right away.

Start with:

- Core needs
- Essential supports
- Then build from there.

Your budget is not just numbers—
It is your child's **support system on paper**.

Make sure it reflects:

- Their needs
- Their goals
- Their daily life

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Self-Direction Budget Review Checklist

Before You Approve Anything

This section helps you carefully review your child's Self-Direction budget before approving it. It walks you through key questions to make sure you understand the budget and that it truly reflects your child's needs.

It is designed to help you feel confident, informed, and in control before making any decisions.

> Think of this as your final check to make sure everything makes sense and works for your child.

Section 1: Understanding the Budget

Question	Yes (✓)	Not Yet	Notes
I understand each section of the budget			
My broker explained the budget step by step			
I know how much is allocated monthly			
I understand what each service is for			

Section 2: Does This Reflect My Child's Needs?

Question	Yes (✓)	Not Yet	Notes
The budget reflects my child's daily needs			
Enough hours are allocated for support			
Services match my child's goals			
Safety needs are addressed			
Behavioral or specialized needs are included			

Section 3: Budget Breakdown

Question	Yes (✓)	Not Yet	Notes
Most of the budget goes to direct support (staffing)			
Administrative costs (broker/FI) are reasonable			
I understand how staff will be paid			
There is a balance between services and supports			

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Section 4: Red Flags Check

Question	Yes (✓)	Not Yet	Notes
I do NOT feel rushed to approve this			
I have had time to review everything carefully			
My questions have been clearly answered			
I fully understand how funds are being used			
Nothing feels confusing or unclear			

Section 5: Flexibility & Changes

Question	Yes (✓)	Not Yet	Notes
I understand that the budget can be adjusted later			
I know who to contact to make changes			
I understand the process for updates			

Before You Approve—Ask These Questions

- *"Does this budget fully reflect my child's needs?"*
- *"Can anything be adjusted before submission?"*
- *"What happens if something is missing later?"*

Important Reminder

Do NOT approve a budget if:

- You do not understand it
- You feel rushed
- It does not reflect your child's needs

You are allowed to say:

- *"I need more time to review this."*
- *"I have questions before I approve."*

Approval = Agreement

Make sure you **fully understand and agree** before signing anything.

This is not just paperwork. **THIS IS YOUR CHILD'S SUPPORT SYSTEM.**

- Take your time.
- Ask questions.
- Advocate confidently.

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Is Self-Direction Right for Me?

Quick Decision Tool for Parents

This section helps you decide whether Self-Direction is a good fit for you and your child. It walks you through simple questions to help you think about your comfort level, time, and ability to manage services.

The goal is to help you make a choice that feels right for your family—not rushed or confusing.

Think of this as a quick check to see if Self-Direction matches your needs and lifestyle.

Question	Yes (✓)	Not Sure	No
I want more control over my child's services			
I am willing to learn how Self-Direction works			
I can stay organized (or am willing to try)			
I am comfortable asking questions and advocating			
I want to choose who works with my child			
I can communicate regularly with my team (broker, care manager, FI)			
I am okay with being involved in decision-making			
I want services tailored specifically to my child			
I am willing to review and manage a budget (with support)			
I am prepared to follow up and stay engaged			

What Your Answers Mean

If You Answered…	What It Suggests
Mostly Yes	Self-Direction may be a great fit for your family
Mix of Yes & Not Sure	You may benefit from learning more before deciding
Mostly No	Traditional services may be a better starting point

You do **not** have to decide right away.

You can:

- Start with traditional services
- Transition to Self-Direction later

Parent Tip
Self-Direction is not about doing everything alone—it's about:

Having support + control + flexibility

The question is *not*:

"Is Self-Direction perfect?"

The question is:

"Does this give my child what they need?"

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Self-Direction vs. Traditional Services

Side-by-Side Comparison

Area	Self-Direction	Traditional Services
Control	You have control over services, staff, and supports	Agency controls services and staffing
Flexibility	Highly flexible—services can be customized	More structured and fixed
Choice of Staff	You can choose who works with your child	Agency assigns staff
Service Design	Tailored to your child's specific needs	Based on agency programs and availability
Schedule	Flexible schedule based on your needs	Set schedules determined by agency
Budget	You help manage and understand the budget	Agency manages all funding
Responsibility	Higher—requires involvement and oversight	Lower—agency handles most responsibilities
Support System	You build your own team (broker, FI, staff)	Agency provides full service team
Ease of Setup	Takes time to set up initially	Easier and quicker to start
Ongoing Management	Requires ongoing communication and tracking	Less hands-on for parents
Customization	Highly individualized	More standardized services
Best For Families Who…	Want control, flexibility, and involvement	Prefer structure and less responsibility

Pros & Cons of Self-Direction

✅ Pros	⚠️ Cons
More control over services and supports	Requires more responsibility and involvement
Ability to choose your child's staff	Finding and managing staff can be challenging
Flexible and personalized services	Can feel overwhelming at first
Budget can be tailored to your child's needs	Must understand and manage the budget
Greater independence and choice for your child	Requires ongoing coordination and follow-up
Ability to adjust services over time	Changes can take time to process
Can create a more meaningful support system	Not all brokers provide strong support

There is no "right" or "wrong" choice, only what works best for your child and your family.

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Top Mistakes Parents Make in Self-Direction

Mistake	What It Looks Like	Why It's a Problem	What to Do Instead
Rushing into Self-Direction	Starting without fully understanding the process	Leads to confusion and poor planning	Take time to learn and ask questions first
Not understanding the budget	Signing off without knowing how funds are used	Budget may not reflect your child's needs	Ask for a full explanation before approving
Choosing the wrong broker	Selecting someone without asking questions	Poor guidance and delays in services	Interview brokers and choose carefully
Not reviewing the service plan (ISP)	Accepting a plan that feels incomplete	Services may not match your child's needs	Review and request changes before approval
Not keeping records	Losing track of documents and communication	Causes delays and repeated work	Use your binder and keep copies of everything
Not following up	Waiting for others to take action	Leads to delays in services starting	Follow up regularly and track communication
Underestimating responsibilities	Thinking Self-Direction requires little involvement	Can lead to mismanagement of services	Stay actively involved and informed
Ignoring red flags	Overlooking poor communication or unclear information	Problems may worsen over time	Address issues early and escalate if needed
Not asking questions	Accepting information without clarity	Misunderstanding services and rights	Ask until you fully understand
Not adjusting the budget over time	Keeping the same plan even when needs change	Services may become ineffective	Request updates as your child's needs evolve

Self-Direction = More Control + More Responsibility

Self-Direction works best when you are:

- Informed
- Organized
- Actively involved

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Financial Supports (Medicaid & SSI)

What You Need to Access and Sustain Services

This section explains the financial programs that help pay for your child's care and services. Medicaid covers most OPWDD services, while SSI provides monthly financial support.

You will learn how to apply, what to expect, and why these supports are so important.

> Think of this as the foundation—these programs make it possible for your child to receive services and support.

Medicaid (VERY IMPORTANT)

- Medicaid is the **primary insurance** that pays for most OPWDD services, including:
  - Community Habilitation
  - Respite
  - Day Programs
  - Residential Services
  - Self-Direction

Your child must have Medicaid to receive these services.

How to Apply for Medicaid

- https://nystateofhealth.ny.gov
  1-855-355-5777

→ This is the official New York State website where you can apply online, check your status, and manage your account.

What You May Need to Apply

- Proof of identity (birth certificate, Social Security number)
- Proof of income (if applicable)
- Medical or disability documentation
- Address verification

Keep copies of everything you submit.

Important Notes About Medicaid

- Approval may take time—follow up regularly
- You must keep Medicaid active (renew when required)
- If Medicaid lapses, ***services can stop***

SSI (Supplemental Security Income)

- SSI is a **monthly financial benefit** for individuals with disabilities who meet eligibility requirements.

It helps families with:

- Daily expenses
- Care-related costs
- Basic financial support

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How to Apply for SSI
https://www.ssa.gov/ssi
1-800-772-1213
→ You can apply online, by phone, or in person at a Social Security office.

What SSI May Require

- Medical documentation
- Proof of disability
- Financial information (income/resources)

Important Notes About SSI

- SSI eligibility is based on:
  - Disability
  - Income/resources

Approval may take several months
If approved, SSI can help support your child's long-term needs

Timelines & What to Expect

Stage	Timeline
Medicaid	1–3 months
Evaluations	1–4 months
Eligibility	1–3 months
Services	3–12+ months

How Medicaid & SSI Work Together

Program	What It Does
Medicaid	Pays for services (healthcare, OPWDD supports)
SSI	Provides monthly financial income

Many individuals who receive SSI are also eligible for Medicaid.

Parent Tips

- Apply as early as possible
- Follow up on your application status
- Keep all documents organized
- Ask for help if needed (Care Manager, agencies, etc.)

Common Mistakes to Avoid

- Waiting too long to apply
- Not submitting complete documents
- Missing renewal deadlines
- Not following up on status

IMPORTANT

- Medicaid = Access to Services and SSI = Financial Support (Both Are Important)

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Medicaid & SSI Application Tracker

Track Your Progress and Stay on Top of Applications

Program	Step	Date Started	Date Completed	Status (✓ / In Progress)	Notes / Follow-Up
Medicaid	Application Submitted				
Medicaid	Documents Submitted				
Medicaid	Interview (if required)				
Medicaid	Approval Received				
Medicaid	Coverage Active				
SSI	Application Submitted				
SSI	Documents Submitted				
SSI	Interview Scheduled				
SSI	Interview Completed				
SSI	Decision Received				
SSI	Benefits Started				

Follow-up Log

Program	Last Contact Date	Who You Spoke To	Next Follow-Up Date	Notes
Medicaid				
SSI				

⚠️ Important Reminders

- Always ask for confirmation numbers when applying
- Write down the name of the person you spoke with
- Follow up if you do not hear back within 7–10 days
- Keep copies of all submitted documents

Do not assume everything is moving forward—
Follow up regularly to keep your application active

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What to Do If Medicaid or SSI Is Denied (Appeals Guide)

A Denial Is Not the End—You Have Options

This section guides you through what to do if your child's application for Medicaid or SSI is denied. It explains the appeal process in simple steps and shows you how to respond, gather documents, and move forward.

A denial can feel discouraging, but it does not mean the process is over.

> Think of this as your next-step plan—helping you challenge the decision and continue advocating for your child.

⚠️ First: Do Not Panic

A denial does **NOT** mean your child is not eligible.

It often means:

- Missing documents
- Incomplete information
- Need for additional proof

Many families are approved **after an appeal**

Step 1: Read the Denial Letter Carefully

What to Look For	Why It Matters
Reason for denial	Tells you what needs to be fixed
Deadline to appeal	You must act quickly
Instructions to appeal	Follow exactly

➡ Do not ignore this letter.

Step 2: Act Quickly (Deadlines Matter)

Program	Typical Appeal Deadline
Medicaid	Usually within **60 days**
SSI	Usually within **60 days**

➡ File your appeal as soon as possible

Step 3: Contact the Agency Immediately

Medicaid (NY State of Health)
1-855-355-5777
https://nystateofhealth.ny.gov

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SSI (Social Security)
1-800-772-1213
https://www.ssa.gov/ssi

Say: *"I received a denial and would like to file an appeal. Can you guide me through the next steps?"*

Step 4: Identify What Is Missing

Common reasons for denial:

Issue	What to Do
Missing documents	Submit all required paperwork
Incomplete medical records	Request updated reports
Not enough proof of disability	Provide detailed evaluations
Income documentation issues	Resubmit accurate financial info

Step 5: Gather Strong Supporting Documents
You may need:

- Updated evaluations
- Medical records
- Doctor letters
- School records (IEP)
- Proof of disability impact

The stronger your documentation, the better your chances.

Step 6: Submit Your Appeal
Follow instructions in your denial letter

- Submit:
  - Appeal form
  - Supporting documents

Keep copies of everything you submit.

Step 7: Prepare for a Hearing (If Required)
Sometimes you may need to attend a hearing.

- Be ready to explain:
  - Your child's needs
  - Daily challenges
  - Why services/support are necessary

Be clear, honest, and specific

Step 8: Ask for Help

- You do not have to do this alone.
  You can get support from:
  - Your **Care Manager**
  - Advocacy organizations
  - Legal assistance (if needed)

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Free Advocacy Resources to help you understand and navigate appeals.

Parent to Parent

- https://www.ptopnys.org/

INCLUDEnyc

- https://includenyc.org

⚠️ Common Mistakes to Avoid

Mistake	What to Do Instead
Ignoring deadlines	Act immediately
Submitting incomplete documents	Double-check everything
Not asking questions	Call and clarify
Giving up after denial	Appeal and try again

You can say: *"I would like to formally appeal this decision and submit additional documentation."*

Denial = **Next Step, Not Final Answer**

Stay:

- Organized
- Persistent
- Informed

➡️ REMEMBER! You are advocating for your child's access to care and support.

- Do not stop at "no."
- Ask questions.
- Submit again.
- Just……

KEEP GOING!!!!

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Appeal Tracking Log (Parent Tool)

Track Every Step of Your Medicaid or SSI Appeal

Program	Step	Date Started	Date Completed	Status (✓ / In Progress)	Notes
Medicaid / SSI	Denial Letter Received				
Medicaid / SSI	Reason for Denial Reviewed				
Medicaid / SSI	Appeal Filed				
Medicaid / SSI	Documents Gathered				
Medicaid / SSI	Documents Submitted				
Medicaid / SSI	Appeal Confirmation Received				
Medicaid / SSI	Hearing Scheduled (if applicable)				
Medicaid / SSI	Hearing Completed				
Medicaid / SSI	Final Decision Received				

Appeal Communication log

Date	Agency (Medicaid/SSI)	Person Spoken To	Phone/Email	Summary of Conversation	Next Steps	Follow-Up Date

Important Reminders

- ☐ Always note the **date you filed your appeal**
- ☐ Ask for a **confirmation number**
- ☐ Keep copies of everything you submit
- ☐ Follow up if you do not hear back within **7–10 days**

Documents Checklist (KEEP EVERYTHING!)

- ☐ Denial letter (keep a copy)
- ☐ Appeal form submitted
- ☐ Medical records Evaluations
- ☐ Doctor letters
- ☐ School records (IEP, if applicable); Any additional supporting documents

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What Parents Often Experience

(And Why This Matters)

If you are feeling overwhelmed trying to get services for your child, you are not alone.

Many families quickly realize that this system is not always easy to navigate. You may find yourself making multiple calls, waiting for responses that never come, or being told there are no available services. At times, it can feel confusing, frustrating, and even exhausting.

These challenges are very common. Families often experience delays in communication, difficulty finding providers, long approval timelines, and unclear guidance about what to do next. On top of that, managing services such as Medicaid, SSI, and Self-Direction can feel like a lot to take, especially when you are also caring for your child every day.

It is important to understand that these barriers are not a reflection of you; they are part of a complex system that many families struggle to navigate.

The good news is that there are ways to move through these challenges.

The table below breaks down the most common barriers parents face and gives you clear, practical steps you can take to keep things moving forward. This is meant to help you feel more prepared, more confident, and more in control as you advocate for your child.

You can do this, and you do not have to figure it out alone.

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Common Barriers & Solutions

What to Expect—and How to Push Through

Barrier	What It Looks Like	What to Do
Delays in Communication	Calls not returned Emails unanswered, long gaps in updates	Call your DDRO directly Follow up weekly (or more if urgent) Keep a call log (date, name, outcome) Email after calls to create a paper trail
No Available Providers	"There is a waitlist." "We don't have staff available."	Ask for multiple agencies Contact providers yourself Join parent networks Ask for expanded provider lists
Delays in Eligibility or Approval	Slow document review No updates from OPWDD	Call DDRO regularly Confirm documents were received Ask if anything is missing Request a timeline
Confusion About the Process	Feeling overwhelmed Unsure what step comes next	Ask Care Manager to explain step-by-step Attend trainings (OPWDD, YAI, INCLUDEnyc) Use this handbook Ask questions as needed
Poor Care Management Support	Lack of communication No follow-up Unclear guidance	Request regular updates State expectations clearly Contact CMO Request a new Care Manager if needed
Self-Direction Challenges	Don't understand the budget Difficulty finding staff Limited broker support	Ask for clear explanations Do not approve what you don't understand Interview brokers Start small and build over time
Medicaid or SSI Issues	Application delays Denials Coverage interruptions	Follow up regularly Keep copies of documents Appeal denials Track renewals
Burnout & Stress	**Feeling exhausted** Overwhelmed Feeling alone	Use respite services Connect with other parents Take breaks when possible Ask for help

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Quick Response Cheat Sheet

Who to Call for Each Problem

Problem You're Facing	Who to Contact	Phone / Website	What to Say
No response/delays from OPWDD	Your DDRO Office	See regional numbers (DDRO section)	*"I am following up on my child's case. Can you provide a status update?"*
Don't understand the next steps	Care Manager	Your assigned contact	*"Can you walk me through the next steps clearly?"*
Care Manager not responsive	Care Management Organization (CMO)	**ACA:** 833-320-6589 **Care Design NY:** 631-761-8500	*"I need support with communication. I may need a new Care Manager."*
Need services, but no providers are available	Care Manager + Provider Agencies	Ask for a provider list	*"Can you provide multiple agencies? I am actively looking for services."*
Issues with the Self-Direction budget or broker	Self-Direction Broker	Your assigned broker	*"I need a full explanation of my budget and options."*
Serious concerns with the broker	Care Manager / CMO	See above	*"I have concerns about my broker and need guidance or a change."*
Payment or payroll issues (Self-Direction)	Fiscal Intermediary (FI)	Example: Braverhood (see sample)	*"I have a question about payroll/payment for services."*
Medicaid application or coverage issues	NY State of Health	1-855-355-5777 https://nystateofhealth.ny.gov	*"I need help with my Medicaid application/status."*
SSI application or denial	Social Security (SSI)	1-800-772-1213 https://www.ssa.gov/ssi	*"I would like to check my application or file an appeal."*
Denied services / need advocacy help	INCLUDEnyc / The Arc NY	includenyc.org	*"I need help understanding or appealing a decision."*
General confusion or overwhelmed	Parent Support Organizations	YAI.orgincludenyc.org	*"I need guidance on navigating services for my child."*

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Parent Tip
When you call, always:

- Write down the name of the person you spoke to
- Ask for a reference or case number
- Note the date and outcome of the call

When something goes wrong, there is **always someone to call**
The key is:

- Knowing ***who***
- Knowing ***what to say***
- Following up consistently

You are not expected to know everything—**but you are allowed to ask, follow up, and advocate until you get answers.**

DECISION TREE: RESPONDING TO SYSTEM BARRIERS

What to Do When Services Stall or Problems Arise

START HERE

What is the main issue?

1 COMMUNICATION DELAYS

No response, unanswered emails/calls

Step 1
Follow up (call + email) within 3–5 days

Step 2
Document attempt (date, name, outcome)

Did you receive a response?

- **YES** → Continue coordination
- **NO** → **Step 3** Follow up again within 5–7 days

Still no response?

Contact supervisor or agency main line
Escalate concern

2 PROVIDER SHORTAGE

"No staff available" / waitlists

Step 1
Request additional provider options

Step 2
Contact multiple agencies directly

Is a provider available?

- **YES** → Begin intake process
- **NO** → **Step 3**
  - Expand geographic search
  - Explore alternative services

Still no services?

Notify Care Manager
Request interim supports

3 ELIGIBILITY DELAYS

Application stalled, no updates

Step 1
Confirm all documents were submitted

Step 2
Contact DDRO for status update

Is anything missing?

- **YES** → Submit immediately
- **NO** → **Step 3** Request timeline

Delay continues?

Escalate to supervisor
Increase follow-up frequency

4 POOR CARE MANAGEMENT

Lack of communication, no progress

Step 1
Contact Care Manager directly

Step 2
Request update or meeting

Improvement?

- **YES** → Continue monitoring
- **NO** → **Step 3** Contact CMO

Still unresolved?

Request supervisor involvement
Request new Care Manager

5 PARENT BURNOUT

Exhaustion, frustration, withdrawal

Step 1
Acknowledge and normalize feelings

Step 2
Assess immediate needs

Step 3
- Connect to respite services
- Suggest support networks

Is stress improving?

- **YES** → Continue support
- **NO** → Increase check-ins + referrals

QUICK RULE ACROSS ALL BARRIERS

Follow up again → Document everything → Escalate when needed

CORE DECISION FRAMEWORK

When something goes wrong, always ask:

1. What is the barrier?
2. What action has already been taken?
3. What is the next level of follow-up?
4. Who needs to be involved next?

BEST PRACTICE REMINDER

- Do not wait for systems to resolve issues on their own
- Do not assume someone else is following up
- Do not stop at one attempt

PERSISTENCE MOVES CASES FORWARD

SIMPLE TAKEAWAY

Identify
Act
Follow up
Escalate

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Parent Advocacy: Your Role

You Are Your Child's Strongest Advocate

This section explains the important role you play in making sure your child receives the services and support they need. It highlights how speaking up, asking questions, and staying involved can make a real difference.

You don't need to know everything—you just need to stay engaged and keep moving forward.

Think of this as your reminder that your voice matters and your advocacy is powerful.

What Advocacy *Really* Means

Parent advocacy means speaking up, asking questions, and making sure your child receives the services and support they need**.**

You are not just a parent in this system—you are:

- The expert on your child
- The decision-maker
- The voice ensuring your child is seen, heard, and supported

No one knows your child better than you.

Why Advocacy Is So Important

The service system can be:

- Complex
- Slow-moving
- Difficult to navigate

Because of this, services do not always move forward automatically.

This is where ***you*** come in.

Without advocacy:

- Things can be delayed
- Needs may be overlooked
- Opportunities may be missed

With advocacy:

- Services move forward
- Needs are clearly communicated
- Your child receives better support

What Advocacy Looks Like in Action

Advocacy can be simple and powerful:

- ☐ Following up on calls and emails
- ☐ Asking questions until you understand

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- ☐ Requesting services your child needs
- ☐ Speaking up when something doesn't feel right
- ☐ Keeping records and staying organized
- ☐ Making sure your child's voice and needs are prioritized

What You Are Allowed to Do
You have the right to:

- Ask questions
- Request explanations
- Disagree respectfully
- Request changes (services, staff, Care Manager, broker)
- Appeal decisions
- Take your time before approving anything

Parent Empowerment Statements
You can say:
"I would like a clearer explanation."
"This does not reflect my child's needs."
"What are my options?"
"I need time to review this."

You Are Not Alone: Key Support Organizations
These organizations are here to **support YOU**:

Parent to Parent of New York State
https://www.parenttoparentnys.org
→ Connects you with other parents who understand your experience
→ Provides emotional support and guidance
Sometimes the best advice comes from another parent

YAI (Services, Evaluations & Family Support)
212-273-6100
https://www.yai.org
→ Offers:

- Evaluations and services
- Family support resources
- Educational materials

A trusted organization for both services and guidance

INCLUDEnyc (Parent Training & Advocacy)
212-677-4660
https://includenyc.org
→ Provides:

- Free workshops and trainings
- Advocacy support
- Help understanding your rights

Excellent for learning how to navigate the system confidently

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Building Your Support Network

- Advocacy is stronger when you are supported.
- Consider building your network with:
- Other parents
- Support groups
- Advocacy organizations
- Your Care Manager (when effective)
- Professionals who understand the system

Common Advocacy Challenges

You may feel:

- Intimidated
- Overwhelmed
- Unsure of what to say

This is normal.
Advocacy is something you ***learn over time***.

Parent Tip

You do not have to be perfect—you just have to be **persistent**.

- Keep asking
- Keep following up

…….Keep going

Advocacy is not about being difficult

- It is about making sure your child gets what they need.

You are doing one of the most important jobs there is.
Even when it feels hard

YOUR VOICE MAKES A DIFFERENCE.

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Parent Advocacy Checklist

Daily & Weekly Actions to Stay on Track

This section gives you simple daily and weekly actions to help you stay organized and keep things moving forward. It breaks advocacy into small, manageable steps so you don't feel overwhelmed.

By using this checklist, you can stay on track, follow up consistently, and make sure nothing falls through the cracks.

Think of this as your guide to staying organized, consistent, and confident as you advocate for your child.

Daily Quick Check (5–10 Minutes)
Simple actions to keep things moving

Task	✓	Notes
Check for missed calls, voicemails, or emails		
Review any updates or messages from providers/agencies		
Write down any new questions or concerns		
Add notes to your call log or binder		

Weekly Advocacy Actions

Task	✓	Notes
Follow up on at least one pending issue (OPWDD, Medicaid, SSI, services)		
Contact your Care Manager for updates (if needed)		
Check status of applications or services		
Reach out to providers if waiting for services		
Review your child's current needs and any changes		
Organize documents (evaluations, letters, forms)		
Update your tracking tools (application log, service tracker)		

Communication Checklist (Every Time You Call)

Task	✓	Notes
Write down the date of the call		
Record the name of the person you spoke to		
Ask for a reference or case number		
Write down key information discussed		
Confirm next steps and timeline		
Set a follow-up date		

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Monthly Advocacy Check-In

Task	✓	Notes
Review all services your child is receiving		
Identify any gaps in services or supports		
Check Medicaid/SSI status (active, renewals, updates)		
Review Self-Direction budget (if applicable)		
Evaluate if your Care Manager and providers are responsive		
Plan next steps or goals for the upcoming month		

If Something Feels Stuck

Action	✓
Followed up at least twice	
Contacted a supervisor or main office	
Asked if anything is missing	
Requested a clear timeline	
Reached out to an advocacy organization	

Parent Empowerment Reminders

- ☐ You are allowed to follow up
- ☐ You are allowed to ask questions
- ☐ You are allowed to say "I don't understand"
- ☐ You are allowed to request changes

Ask yourself

"Did I take at least one step forward this week?"

That's it. One step at a time.

Advocacy is not about doing everything at once.
It's about:

- Staying consistent
- Staying organized
- Staying engaged

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Parent Organization Binder System

Stay Organized. Stay Prepared. Stay in Control. You've Got THIS!

This section shows you how to organize all of your child's important documents in one place. From evaluations and letters to applications and notes, having everything together makes it easier to stay on top of the process.

Being organized can help prevent delays, reduce stress, and make communication with agencies much smoother.

> Think of this as your command center—keeping everything you need in one place so you feel prepared and in control.

Why This Matters
Navigating services means managing a lot of paperwork, phone calls, and follow-ups. Having everything in one place will help you:

- Stay organized
- Respond quickly when asked for documents
- Avoid delays in services
- Feel more confident and in control
- Think of this binder as your **main tool for managing your child's care**.

🗂️ How to Set Up Your Binder

- Use a **3-ring binder** (or digital folder system) with labeled tabs.

Recommended Sections (Tabs)

1. Child Information
Include:

- Birth certificate
- Social Security card
- Medicaid card
- Insurance information

Keep copies—never store originals in the binder.

2. Medical Records
Include:

- Medical diagnoses
- Doctor reports
- Medication list
- Appointment summaries

Update this section regularly.

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3. Evaluations (VERY IMPORTANT)
Include:
- Psychological evaluations
- Psychosocial evaluations
- Autism evaluations
- Any standardized testing reports

This is one of the most important sections—keep it complete and current.

4. OPWDD Documents
Include:
- Eligibility letters
- OPWDD correspondence
- Front Door confirmation
- Service approvals

Keep everything you receive from OPWDD.

5. Care Management
Include:
- Care Manager contact information
- Individualized Service Plan (ISP)
- Notes from meetings

Write down updates after each conversation.

6. Service Providers
Include:
- Agency names and contacts
- Staff assigned to your child
- Schedules
- Service agreements

Keep track of who is providing what service.

7. Medicaid & Financial
Include:
- Medicaid approval letters
- SSI documents
- Budget information (if Self-Direction)
- Financial correspondence

8. Communication Log
Include:
- Call Tracking Log (use the template provided)
- Email printouts (if needed)

This helps you track everything and follow up effectively.

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9. School Records (if applicable)
Include:
- IEP (Individualized Education Program)
- School evaluations
- Progress reports

10. Notes & Observations
Include:
- Behavior notes
- Concerns or changes
- Questions for providers

This helps you advocate with real examples.

How to Use Your Binder Effectively
- Bring it to all meetings and appointments
- Update it weekly (even briefly)
- Keep documents in order (most recent in front)
- Add new sections if needed

Common Mistakes to Avoid
- Keeping papers in different places
- Losing evaluation reports
- Not writing down conversations
- Waiting too long to organize documents
-
-

Pro Tip: Go Digital Too
If possible:
- Scan documents
- Save them in folders on your phone or computer
- Email copies to yourself

This gives you backup access anytime.

Final Note to Parents
- This binder is more than just paperwork; it is your **system for staying organized, informed, and prepared**.
- When systems feel overwhelming, organization gives you clarity.
  When communication is unclear, documentation gives you strength.
- This binder helps you **advocate with confidence**.

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Step-by-Step Service Timeline Tracker

Track Your Progress from Start to Services

Instructions

- Use this tracker to monitor each step in the process.
- Check off steps as you complete them
- Write dates to stay on schedule
- Follow up if delays occur

Service Timeline Tracker

Step	Task	Date Started	Date Completed	Status (✓ / In Progress)	Notes / Follow-Up
1	Applied for Medicaid				
2	Medicaid Approved				
3	Scheduled Evaluations				
4	Completed Evaluations				
5	Received Evaluation Reports				
6	Registered with OPWDD				
7	Attended Front Door Session				
8	Submitted Eligibility Documents				
9	Eligibility Approved				
10	Assigned Care Manager				
11	Completed Initial Meeting (ISP Planning)				
12	Selected Service Providers				
13	Services Authorized				
14	Services Started				
15	Applied for SSI (if applicable)				

Follow-up Tracker

Task	Last Contact Date	Next Follow-Up Date	Notes
Medicaid			
Evaluations			
OPWDD			
Care Manager			
Service Providers			

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Action Plan (First 30 Days)

This section helps you focus on what to do in your first 30 days so you don't feel overwhelmed. It breaks things down into simple, manageable steps to help you get started and build momentum.

Instead of trying to do everything at once, you can take it one step at a time and see real progress.

> Think of this as your starting plan—helping you move forward with clarity and confidence.

Week	Focus	Tasks	Completed (✓)	Notes
Week 1	Get Organized & Start Medicaid	Create Parent Binder / digital folder		
Week 1		Gather documents (birth certificate, insurance, school records)		
Week 1		Apply for Medicaid		
Week 1		Start Call Tracking Log		
Week 2	Schedule Evaluations	Contact 2–3 evaluation agencies		
Week 2		Ask about standardized testing & Medicaid acceptance		
Week 2		Schedule a psychological evaluation		
Week 2		Schedule a psychosocial evaluation		
Week 3	Start OPWDD Process	Register with OPWDD		
Week 3		Sign up for Front Door session		
Week 3		Contact local DDRO office		
Week 3		Ask about required documents		
Week 4	Follow Up & Stay on Track	Confirm evaluation appointments		
Week 4		Follow up on Medicaid status		
Week 4		Attend Front Door session (if scheduled)		
Week 4		Organize documents for submission		

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Service Delay Troubleshooting Guide

This section helps you understand what to do when services are delayed or not moving forward. It walks you through common issues and provides clear steps so you can take action instead of feeling stuck.

Delays are common, but there are ways to address them and keep things progressing.

> Think of this as your problem-solving guide—helping you figure out what's wrong and what to do next.

Issue	What Might Be Happening	What You Should Do	Contact / Action
Medicaid Delay	Application pending or incomplete	Call for status, confirm documents	Medicaid Helpline: 1-800-541-2831
No Evaluation Appointments	Long waitlists	Call multiple agencies, ask for cancellations	Contact DDSO for referrals
No Response from OPWDD	Communication delays	Follow up weekly, log calls	Call local DDRO office
Eligibility Delay	Missing or incomplete documents	Confirm application is complete	Ask OPWDD for timeline
No Care Manager Assigned	Assignment backlog	Request update, follow up frequently	Contact OPWDD
Services Not Started	Staffing or provider delays	Contact agency, request timeline	Ask about alternative providers

Reminder	Action
If no response	Ask to speak to a supervisor
If delayed repeatedly	Reference previous calls and dates
Stay consistent	Follow up regularly and document everything

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Parent Advocacy Scripts (What to Say & When)

USE YOUR VOICE!

This section gives you simple, ready-to-use scripts to help you communicate with agencies, providers, and service coordinators. It shows you what to say in common situations so you don't feel stuck or unsure.

You don't need perfect words; you just need to speak up.

> Think of this as your voice guide, helping you feel more confident, clear, and empowered every time you advocate for your child.

Situation	What to Say	Purpose
Starting the process	"Hello, I'm trying to begin services for my child through OPWDD. Can you guide me on the first steps?"	Opens the conversation clearly and directly
Requesting evaluations	"I need a psychological and psychosocial evaluation with standardized testing for OPWDD. Do you provide that?"	Ensures you receive the correct evaluation
Following up (no response)	"I'm following up on my previous call regarding my child's case. Can you provide an update?"	Keeps your case active
Clarifying next steps	"Can you please explain the next steps and what documents I still need to submit?"	Prevents confusion and delays
When something is unclear	"Can you explain that in a different way? I want to make sure I fully understand."	Ensures clarity
When documents are missing	"Can you confirm if my application is complete, or if anything is missing?"	Avoids delays in processing
Requesting timelines	"Can you give me an estimated timeline for this process?"	Sets expectations
Addressing delays	"I've been waiting for an update. Is there anything I can do to help move this forward?"	Shows engagement and urgency
Speaking to a supervisor	"I would appreciate speaking with a supervisor to better understand how to move this forward."	Escalates respectfully
Starting services	"My child has been approved. When will services begin, and what are the next steps?"	Moves process toward action

Parent Tip

- Speak clearly, stay calm, and take notes. You are advocating—not complaining.

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Service Checklist by Age (Planning Across the Lifespan)

Services Are For All Ages!

This section helps you understand what services to consider at different stages of your child's life, from early childhood through adulthood. It gives you a general guide so you can plan ahead and stay prepared for important transitions.

Every child is different, but knowing what to expect at each stage can make the process feel more manageable.

> Think of this as your long-term roadmap—helping you plan for today while preparing for the future.

Age Range	Focus Area	What to Do	Notes
Birth – 3	Early Intervention	Contact the Early Intervention program	Services are time-sensitive—act early
3 – 5	Preschool Services	Transition to CPSE (Committee on Preschool Special Education)	Begin school-based supports
5 – 12	School-Age Services	Ensure IEP is active and updated	Request evaluations if needed
12 – 14	Early Transition Planning	Begin discussing future goals	Start thinking long-term
14 – 18	Transition Planning	Work with the school on a transition plan (IEP)	Include life skills and vocational goals
18 – 21	Adult Services Preparation	Apply for OPWDD services if not already done	Begin adult service coordination
21+	Adult Services	Access day programs, employment supports, and housing options	Services shift from school to adult systems

Across ALL Ages (Always Do This)

Task	Action
Keep evaluations updated	Ensure reports are current
Maintain Medicaid	Keep coverage active
Stay organized	Use your binder and logs
Advocate consistently	Follow up and ask questions
Build a support team	Doctors, providers, care managers

Reminder

- Planning ahead makes transitions smoother.
- Do not wait until the last minute. Start early.

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Top 10 Things Every Parent Should Know

This section emphasizes the **most important things** to understand as you navigate services for your child. These key points are based on real experiences and are meant to help you avoid common challenges and feel more prepared.

It brings together the most valuable insights in one place so you can move forward with clarity and confidence.

Think of this as your quick guide to what really matters most.

#	Key Insight	What It Means for You
1	**Start Early**	The sooner you begin, the sooner services can be approved and started.
2	**Medicaid is Required**	Most OPWDD services depend on Medicaid—apply as soon as possible.
3	**Evaluations Are Everything**	Strong, standardized evaluations are the foundation of eligibility and services.
4	**You Must Follow Up**	Do not wait—call, check in, and stay on top of your case.
5	**Keep Copies of Everything**	You will need documents multiple times—stay organized.
6	**OPWDD Approves, Agencies Provide**	OPWDD gives approval, but service agencies deliver the actual services.
7	**You Have a Voice**	You can ask questions, request changes, and advocate for your child.
8	**Delays Are Common—Stay Persistent**	Delays happen, but consistent follow-up keeps things moving.
9	**Build a Support Team**	Care managers, providers, and professionals are part of your team—use them.
10	**You Are Not Alone**	Many parents are navigating this—support and guidance are available.

Parent Tip

- You do not have to know everything
- You just have to keep going.

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Full OPWDD Process Flow (Step-by-Step Overview)

From Starting Point to Services

This section gives you a clear, big-picture view of the entire OPWDD process—from the first step of getting started to having services in place. It helps you see how each part connects so you understand where you are and what comes next.

Instead of feeling lost in the process, this overview helps you follow the path with more confidence.

Think of this as your full roadmap—from beginning to services.

Step	What Happens	What You Need to Do	Outcome
1	Apply for Medicaid	Submit application (if not already active)	Medicaid coverage begins
2	Schedule Evaluations	Set up psychological & psychosocial evaluations	Required reports completed
3	Register with OPWDD	Create account / submit initial info	Enter OPWDD system
4	Attend Front Door Session	Learn about services and process	Understand next steps
5	Submit Eligibility Documents	Provide evaluations, diagnosis, records	Application under review
6	Eligibility Determination	OPWDD reviews documents	Approval or request for more info
7	Care Manager Assigned	You are connected to a Care Manager	Begin service planning
8	Develop ISP (Service Plan)	Identify needs, goals, and services	Plan is created
9	Choose Providers	Select agencies for services	Services arranged
10	Service Authorization	OPWDD approves selected services	Ready to begin
11	Services Begin	Providers start working with your child	Ongoing support

Important Notes

- Some steps may overlap
- Some steps may take longer than expected
- You may need to **follow up multiple times**

Parent Tip

- Think of this process as a **journey, not a straight line**.
- Progress happens step by step—with persistence.

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Red Flags & Warning Signs

(When Something May Be Wrong)

This section helps you recognize when something in the process may not be right—such as poor communication, lack of support, or services not meeting your child's needs. It highlights warning signs so you can take action early.

Trust your instincts! If something doesn't feel right, it's okay to question it.

> Think of this as your awareness guide—helping you protect your child and advocate when needed.

Situation	Red Flag	What It Might Mean	What You Should Do
Communication	No response to calls or emails	Your case may not be actively followed	Follow up, document calls, ask for updates
Delays	Long delays with no explanation	Missing documents or system backlog	Ask: "Is anything missing from my file?"
Evaluations	No standardized testing included	Evaluation may not be accepted by OPWDD	Request a proper evaluation with scores
Services	Approved but not started	Staffing or agency issues	Contact provider and ask for start date
Care Manager	Hard to reach or unresponsive	Lack of coordination or oversight	Request a supervisor or new Care Manager
Information	You are confused or unclear	Poor communication from provider/system	Ask for clarification—keep asking questions
Documentation	Asked to resubmit documents repeatedly	Records may not be properly tracked	Keep copies and confirm receipt
Meetings	Your concerns are ignored	Lack of person-centered planning	Speak up and restate your concerns clearly
Pressure	Feeling rushed into decisions	Not enough time to understand options	Ask for time to review and ask questions
Respect	You feel dismissed or unheard	Lack of respect or partnership	Escalate and advocate firmly

⚠️ **Important**

If something does not feel right

Trust your instincts. Ask questions. Follow up.

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Parent Rights & Advocacy Guide

This section helps you understand your rights as a parent and how to use them to support your child. It explains what you are entitled to, what you can ask for, and how to speak up when needed.

Knowing your rights gives you the confidence to make informed decisions and advocate effectively.

> Think of this as your empowerment guide—helping you stand strong and informed as you navigate the system.

Your Right	What It Means	What You Can Do
Right to Information	You have the right to clear explanations	Ask questions until you understand
Right to Participation	You are part of all decisions about your child	Attend meetings and share your input
Right to Copies	You can request copies of all documents	Keep everything organized in your binder
Right to Timely Services	Services should not be unnecessarily delayed	Follow up and request timelines
Right to Respect	You should be treated with dignity and professionalism	Speak up if you feel disrespected
Right to Choose Providers	You can choose service agencies (when options exist)	Ask about available providers
Right to Ask for Changes	You can request changes to services or plans	Contact your Care Manager
Right to a Care Manager	You should have someone coordinating services	Follow up if not assigned
Right to Escalate	You can speak to a supervisor if needed	Request escalation when issues continue
Right to Advocate	You can speak up for your child at all times	Be clear, consistent, and confident

Simple Advocacy Statements You Can Use

- "I want to make sure I understand this clearly."
- "Can you explain the next steps?"
- "I would like an update on my child's case."
- "I am requesting support to move this forward."
- "I would like to speak with a supervisor."

Parent Empowerment Tip

- You are not asking for favors.
  You are advocating for your child's rights.

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Parent Confidence Checklist: Am I Doing This Right?

Use this to check in with yourself throughout the process

This section is here to help you pause and check in with yourself as you move through this process. It's easy to question yourself or feel unsure—but this checklist reminds you that you are taking the right steps.

You are learning, advocating, and showing up for your child—and that matters more than doing everything perfectly.

Think of this as your reminder that you're on the right track, even on the hard days.

Area	Question	Yes (✓)	Not Yet	Notes
Getting Started	I have begun the process (Medicaid, OPWDD, or evaluations)			
Organization	I have a binder or system to keep documents organized			
Evaluations	I have scheduled or completed required evaluations			
Documentation	I keep copies of all important paperwork			
Communication	I track calls, emails, and follow-ups			
Follow-Up	I follow up when I do not receive responses			
Understanding	I ask questions when I do not understand something			
Advocacy	I speak up about my child's needs and concerns			
Support	I know who to contact (DDRO, Care Manager, agencies)			
Persistence	I continue moving forward, even when things are delayed			

Important Reminder

- You do not need to check every box perfectly.
- If you are trying, learning, and showing up for your child, ***you are doing it right.***

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Parent Advocacy Confidence Script Sheet

What to Say, Quick, Clear, and Confident

This section is designed to reassure you and help you reflect on your efforts as you navigate this process. It walks you through simple check-ins to remind you that you are taking the right steps, even when things feel uncertain.

It's not about being perfect; it's about staying present, engaged, and moving forward.

> Think of this as your reassurance tool—reminding you that you are doing more than enough.

When You Need an Update

- "I'm calling to check on the status of my child's case."
- "Can you provide an update and next steps?"
- "When should I expect to hear back?"

When You Don't Understand Something

- "Can you explain that in a different way?"
- "I want to make sure I fully understand—can you walk me through that?"
- "What does that mean for my child's services?"

When You Want to Confirm Information

- "Can you confirm that all documents have been received?"
- "Is my application complete?"
- "Is there anything missing that could delay the process?"

When Things Are Delayed

- "I've been waiting for an update—can you help move this forward?"
- "Is there anything I can do to help speed up the process?"
- "What is the expected timeline from here?"

When You Need Clear Next Steps

- "What should I do next?"
- "What are the next steps after this?"
- "Who should I contact moving forward?"

When You Need to Be More Direct

- "I am concerned about the delay in services."
- "I need support to move this forward for my child."
- "This is important for my child's care, and I need assistance."

When You Need to Escalate

- "I would like to speak with a supervisor."
- "I need additional support with this situation."

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- "Can you connect me with someone who can help resolve this?"

When Requesting a Change (Care Manager/Provider)

- "I would like to request a change to better support my child's needs."
- "I feel additional support is needed at this time."

During Meetings (Advocating for Your Child)

- "This is what my child needs…"
- "I would like this included in the service plan."
- "That does not fully address my child's needs—can we explore other options?"

When You Need Time to Decide

- "I would like time to review this before making a decision."
- "Can you provide this in writing so I can look it over?"

Power Statements (Use Anytime)

- "I want to make sure my child receives the appropriate support."
- "I am advocating for my child's needs."
- "I would like to move forward with the next steps."

How to Use This Sheet

- ☐ Keep it in your binder or phone
- ☐ Use it during calls and meetings
- ☐ Practice saying these phrases out loud

Final Reminder

You do not need perfect words—

You just need to speak up.

- Your voice matters.
- Your child depends on it.
- And you are doing exactly what you're supposed to do.

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Parent Call Scripts

What to Say When You Don't Know What to Say

This section provides simple, ready-to-use language to help you communicate with agencies, providers, and service coordinators. It takes the guesswork out of what to say, especially during stressful or uncertain situations.

These scripts are here to help you feel more confident, clear, and prepared when making calls or following up.

> Think of this as your communication guide, helping you speak up with confidence and purpose.

---

1. General Follow-Up (Any Agency)
Script:
"Hello, my name is [Your Name]. I am calling to follow up on my child's case. I wanted to check the status and see if there are any updates or next steps I should be aware of."

If needed, add:
"I haven't received an update and wanted to make sure everything is moving forward."

2. Checking Application Status (OPWDD / Medicaid / SSI)
Script:
"Hi, I am calling to check the status of my application for my child. Can you please let me know where things stand and if anything is missing?"

Follow-up:
"Is there anything I need to submit to move this forward?"

3. If You Suspect Missing Documents
Script:
"I just want to confirm that all required documents have been received. Can you review my file and let me know if anything is missing or still needed?"

4. When There Are Delays
Script:
"I understand these processes take time, but I wanted to follow up because I haven't received an update. Can you provide a timeline or let me know the next step?"

Add if needed:
"This is important for my child's care, so I want to make sure everything is on track."

5. Speaking with Your Care Manager
Script:
"Hi, I wanted to connect regarding my child's services. Can we review where we are in the process and what the next steps are?"

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If confused:
"Can you break this down for me step-by-step?"

6. If Your Care Manager Is Not Responsive
Script (to CMO):
"Hello, I am calling because I've had difficulty reaching my Care Manager and need support. I would like assistance with communication and possibly discuss reassignment."

7. Looking for Services / Providers
Script:
"I am currently looking for services for my child and was told there may be limited availability. Can you provide additional agencies or resources I can contact?"

8. Questions About Self-Direction Budget
Script:
"I would like a full explanation of my child's Self-Direction budget. Can you walk me through each part so I fully understand how it is being used?"

Important add:
"I am not comfortable approving anything until I understand it clearly."

9. Appealing a Denial (Medicaid / SSI)
Script:
"I recently received a denial letter and would like to formally appeal the decision. Can you guide me through the next steps and what documentation is needed?"

10. When You Feel Overwhelmed
Script:
"I'm feeling a bit overwhelmed with the process and want to make sure I'm doing everything correctly. Can you guide me on what I should focus on next?"

Parent Communication Tips

- Be polite—but firm
- Take notes during every call
- Ask for names and reference numbers
- Don't be afraid to ask the same question twice

You can always say:

- *"Can you explain that in a simpler way?"*
- *"What is the next step?"*
- *"What is the timeline?"*
- *"Who else can I contact if needed?"*

You do not have to say everything perfectly.
What matters is that you speak up, follow up, and keep going**.**

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Glossary of Terms: OPWDD in Plain Language

Understanding the Words You Will Hear

This section explains common terms, acronyms, and language used within the OPWDD system in simple, easy-to-understand words. Many of these terms can feel confusing at first, but understanding them will help you feel more confident and informed.

You don't need to memorize everything here as a reference whenever you need it.

> Think of this as your translation guide—helping you understand the system in plain language.

Term	What It Means (In Plain Language)
OPWDD (Office for People with Developmental Disabilities)	The New York State agency that helps people with developmental disabilities get services and supports.
Front Door Process	The required starting point to apply for OPWDD services. This includes registering, attending an information session, and beginning the eligibility process.
Eligibility	The process of determining if your child qualifies for OPWDD services based on diagnosis and functioning.
DDRO (Developmental Disabilities Regional Office)	Your local OPWDD office helps guide you through eligibility and services.
Medicaid	Health insurance that pays for most OPWDD services. Your child must have Medicaid to receive many supports.
Medicaid Waiver	A program that allows your child to receive services at home or in the community instead of in a facility.
Care Manager	A person assigned to help coordinate your child's services and create a plan based on their needs.
Care Coordination Organization (CCO)	The agency that employs Care Managers and oversees care coordination.
ISP (Individualized Service Plan)	A written plan that outlines your child's goals, needs, and the services they will receive.
Psychological Evaluation	A formal assessment that measures your child's cognitive abilities and helps determine a diagnosis.
Psychosocial Evaluation	An assessment that looks at behavior, emotions, and daily functioning.
Standardized Testing	Formal tests that provide scores and are required for OPWDD eligibility decisions.
Self-Direction	A service option where families have more control over choosing services, staff, and how funds are used.
Broker (Self-Direction Broker)	A person who helps you manage and set up self-directed services and budgets.
Fiscal Intermediary (FI)	An agency that manages payments and paperwork for self-directed services.

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Respite Services	Temporary care gives parents and caregivers a break.
Community Habilitation (Com Hab)	Services that help your child build skills to live more independently (at home or in the community).
Day Habilitation (Day Hab)	Structured daytime programs focused on skill-building and activities.
Residential Services	Housing options for individuals who need support living outside the family home.
SSI (Supplemental Security Income)	Monthly financial support for individuals with disabilities who meet income and eligibility criteria.
IEP (Individualized Education Program)	A school-based plan that outlines your child's educational needs and services.
Service Authorization	Approval for specific services to begin.
Provider Agency	The organization that delivers services (OPWDD approves services, but agencies provide them).

Parent Tip

- You do **not** need to memorize all of these terms.
- Focus on understanding them as you go, and refer to this section whenever needed.

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Parent Self-Care Action Tool

Caring for Yourself While Caring for Your Child

This section helps you take care of yourself while caring for your child. It offers simple ways to check in with how you're feeling and take small steps to rest, reset, and recharge.

You don't need much time; just a few moments each day can make a difference.

Think of this as your reminder to care for yourself, too, because your well-being matters just as much.

Caring for a child with intellectual and developmental disabilities is deeply meaningful—but it can also be exhausting, overwhelming, and emotionally demanding. Many parents spend so much time advocating, coordinating services, and managing daily care that they forget to take care of themselves.

This Self-Care Action Tool is designed to help you ***pause, check in with yourself, and take small, realistic steps toward your own well-being***.

- Self-care does not have to be big or time-consuming.
- It can be simple, quick, and built into your daily life.

This tool helps you:

- Recognize when you need a break
- Take small, manageable actions
- Stay grounded while navigating a complex system

Self-Care Tracker

Question	Yes (✓)	Not Yet	Notes
Did I take a moment to breathe or pause today?			
Did I drink enough water and eat regularly?			
Did I give myself at least 5–10 minutes of quiet time?			
Did I acknowledge how I'm feeling today?			

Simple Self-Care Actions (Choose 1 Per Day)

Action	✓	Notes
Take a short walk (even 5–10 minutes)		
Sit quietly without distractions		
Call or text someone supportive		
Listen to music or something calming		
Step outside for fresh air		
Do something you enjoy (even briefly)		

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Emotional Check-In

Question	Response
Today I feel…	
What is one thing that felt hard today?	
What is one small win today?	
What do I need right now?	

Support Check

Question	Yes (✓)	Not Yet	Notes
Did I ask for help this week?			
Did I use respite or take a break (if available)?			
Did I talk to someone who understands?			

⚠️ Signs You May Need a Break

- Feeling constantly overwhelmed
- Irritable or emotionally drained
- Trouble sleeping or focusing
- Feeling like you're doing everything alone

If you notice these signs, it's time to pause and take care of YOU.

Quick Reset (When You Feel Overwhelmed)

Try this:

- Take a deep breath
- Pause for 60 seconds
- Ask yourself: *"What do I need right now?"*
- Do one small thing to support yourself

Self-care is not selfish.

It is necessary.

When you take care of yourself:

- You think more clearly
- You advocate more effectively
- You support your child more sustainably

You are doing so much.

Even on the hardest days—

You deserve care, rest, and support too.

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Parent Burnout Prevention Plan

Recognize the Signs Early & Take Action

This section helps you recognize the early signs of burnout and take steps to prevent it before it becomes overwhelming. It guides you in checking in with yourself, understanding your limits, and acting when you need support.

Burnout can happen, but with awareness and small steps, it can be managed.

> Think of this as your early warning and support plan, helping you stay balanced and supported.

Parenting a child with special needs, while navigating systems, services, and daily care, can be overwhelming over time. Burnout doesn't happen all at once; it builds slowly through stress, exhaustion, and constant demands.

This tool helps you:

- Recognize early warning signs
- Pause before reaching burnout
- Take simple, realistic action steps

The goal is not perfection—it's **prevention and balance**.

⚠️ Step 1: Know the Warning Signs

Early Signs of Burnout

Sign	✓	Notes
Feeling tired most of the time		
Feeling overwhelmed by small tasks		
Increased frustration or irritability		
Difficulty focusing or making decisions		
Feeling emotionally drained		

Moderate Burnout Signs

Sign	✓	Notes
Feeling constantly stressed or anxious		
Trouble sleeping		
Feeling unsupported or alone		
Loss of motivation		
Avoiding calls, emails, or responsibilities		

🚫 Severe Burnout Signs (Take Immediate Action)

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Sign	✓	Notes
Feeling hopeless or stuck		
Emotional shutdown or numbness		
Frequent crying or emotional overwhelm		
Physical exhaustion that doesn't improve		
Feeling like you "can't do this anymore"		

Step 2: Identify Your Current Level

Level	Where Are You?
Early	I'm starting to feel it
Moderate	I'm overwhelmed
Severe	I'm exhausted and struggling

Step 3: Take Action (Based on Your Level)

If You're at **EARLY** Stage

- Take short daily breaks (5–10 minutes)
- Reduce non-essential tasks
- Talk to someone you trust
- Use your Self-Care Tool daily

If You're at the **MODERATE** Stage

- Use respite services (if available)
- Ask for help (family, friends, providers)
- Delegate tasks where possible
- Set boundaries (it's okay to say no)
- Schedule intentional rest time

If You're at the **SEVERE** Stage

- Reach out for support immediately
- Contact a trusted person
- Speak to a professional (doctor, therapist)
- Prioritize rest over everything else
- Reduce responsibilities where possible

You do NOT have to carry everything alone

Step 4: Build Your Support Plan

Support Type	Who / What
Emotional Support	(friend, family, parent group)
Practical Help	(respite, caregiver, services)
Professional Support	(doctor, therapist, agency)
Advocacy Support	(Care Manager, organizations)

Step 5: Weekly Reset Plan

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Question	Response
What drained me this week?	
What helped me this week?	
What do I need more of?	
What can I reduce next week?	

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Parent Wellness Plan

Simple Daily & Weekly Support for You

How to Use This Page

- This is your **quick reset and grounding tool**.
- You don't need to do everything—just focus on **small, realistic steps** each day and week.
- The goal is consistency, not perfection.

DAILY WELLNESS (5–10 Minutes)

✓ Check-In (Circle or Mark One)

Today I Feel:	✓
Calm / Okay	
A Little Stressed	
Overwhelmed	
Exhausted	

Basic Needs Check

Task	✓
I drank water today	
I ate regular meals	
I paused and took a breath	

Do ONE Small Thing for Yourself

- ☐ Take a short walk
- ☐ Sit quietly for a few minutes Listen to music
- ☐ Step outside for fresh air
- ☐ Call/text someone supportive

Just **one is enough**

QUICK RESET (WHEN OVERWHELMED)

- ☐ Stop
- ☐ Take a deep breath
- ☐ Ask: *"What do I need right now?"*

Do one small thing

WEEKLY WELLNESS RESET (10–15 Minutes)

Reflect:

Question	Response
What felt hard this week?	
What went well?	
What do I need more of?	
What can I let go of next week?	

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Take One Action

- ☐ Ask for help
- ☐ Schedule a break
- ☐ Follow up on something important
- ☐ Reduce one stressor

MY SUPPORT SYSTEM

Type of Support	Who
Emotional Support	
Practical Help	
Professional Support	
Advocacy Support	

⚠️ WHEN TO PAUSE & TAKE CARE OF YOU

If you feel:

- Constantly overwhelmed
- Exhausted
- Irritable or emotionally drained

This is your signal to **slow down and reset**

REMINDERS FOR YOU

- You are doing enough
- You don't have to do everything today
- It's okay to ask for help
- **Small steps still count**

Your Weekly Goal
"Did I take at least one moment for myself this week?"
That's it.

You are carrying a lot—and you are doing an incredible job. Trust me! I KNOW!
But your well-being matters too.

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Closing Message: My Special Note to You

If there is one thing I want you to take away from this handbook, it is this:

You are doing more than navigating a very complex system; you are advocating for your child's life, growth, and future.

This journey is not easy. There will be moments when things feel overwhelming, unclear, or even discouraging. **You will CRY often**! You will experience delays, unanswered calls, or feel unheard. At times, you may question whether you're doing enough or doing it "right."

But those moments do not define you.
What defines you is your persistence.

Every phone call you make.
Every question you ask.
Every form you complete.
Every time you follow up—

It all matters.

Even when it doesn't feel like progress, it is.

And I want you to know something very important:

I have been there—through all of it!

The tears
The sleepless nights
The burnout.
The stress.
The exhaustion.
The moments of feeling completely alone.

There were times when it felt like too much. Times when I questioned everything. *But I never gave up*. I continued to advocate, step by step, even when it was hard.

And along the way, I learned something just as important:

I had to take care of myself, too.

Because when I take time to rest, to breathe, and to reset,
I am able to come back even stronger, clearer, and more effective for my child.

There is no perfect way to do this. You do not need to have all the answers, nor do you need to do everything perfectly. What matters most is that you continue, step by step, call by call, decision by decision.

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Because you are showing up.
And that is everything.

You know your child better than anyone else. Your voice matters. Your role is essential. And your advocacy—whether quiet or strong—makes a real difference in your child's life.

There will be challenges, yes. But there will also be progress. Growth. Breakthroughs. Moments where things begin to come together.

Trust that.

And on the days when it feels heavy, come back to this:

- You are doing something incredibly important.
- You are building a path for your child.
- You are making a difference—even when you can't see it yet.
- You are not alone in this.
- And…..**You are more capable than you think….Just Keep Going!**

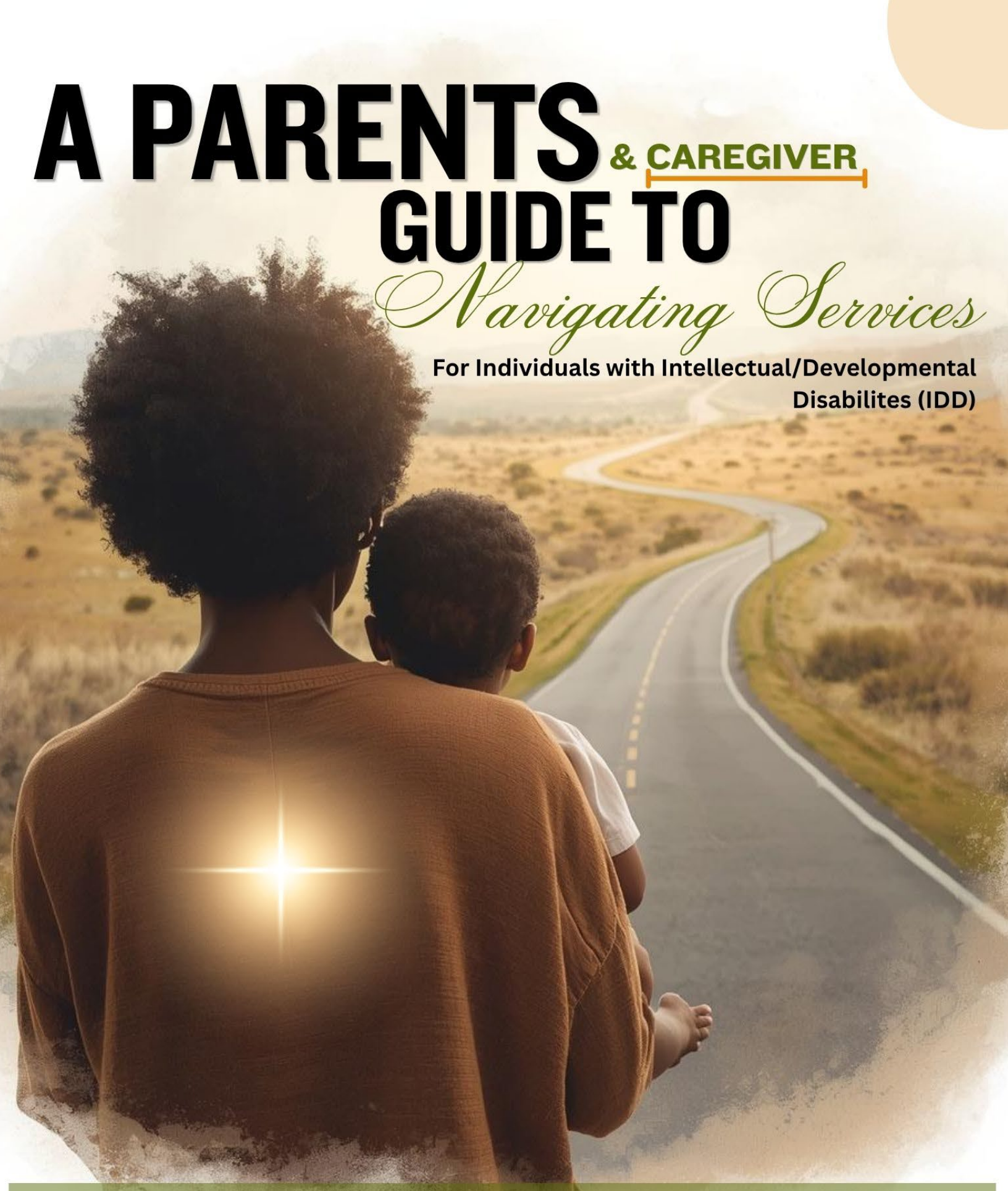
- Dr. Sabretta Alford

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For More Information Contact: Sabretta.Alford@gmail.com
We can discuss your needs and determine the best approach moving forward.

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